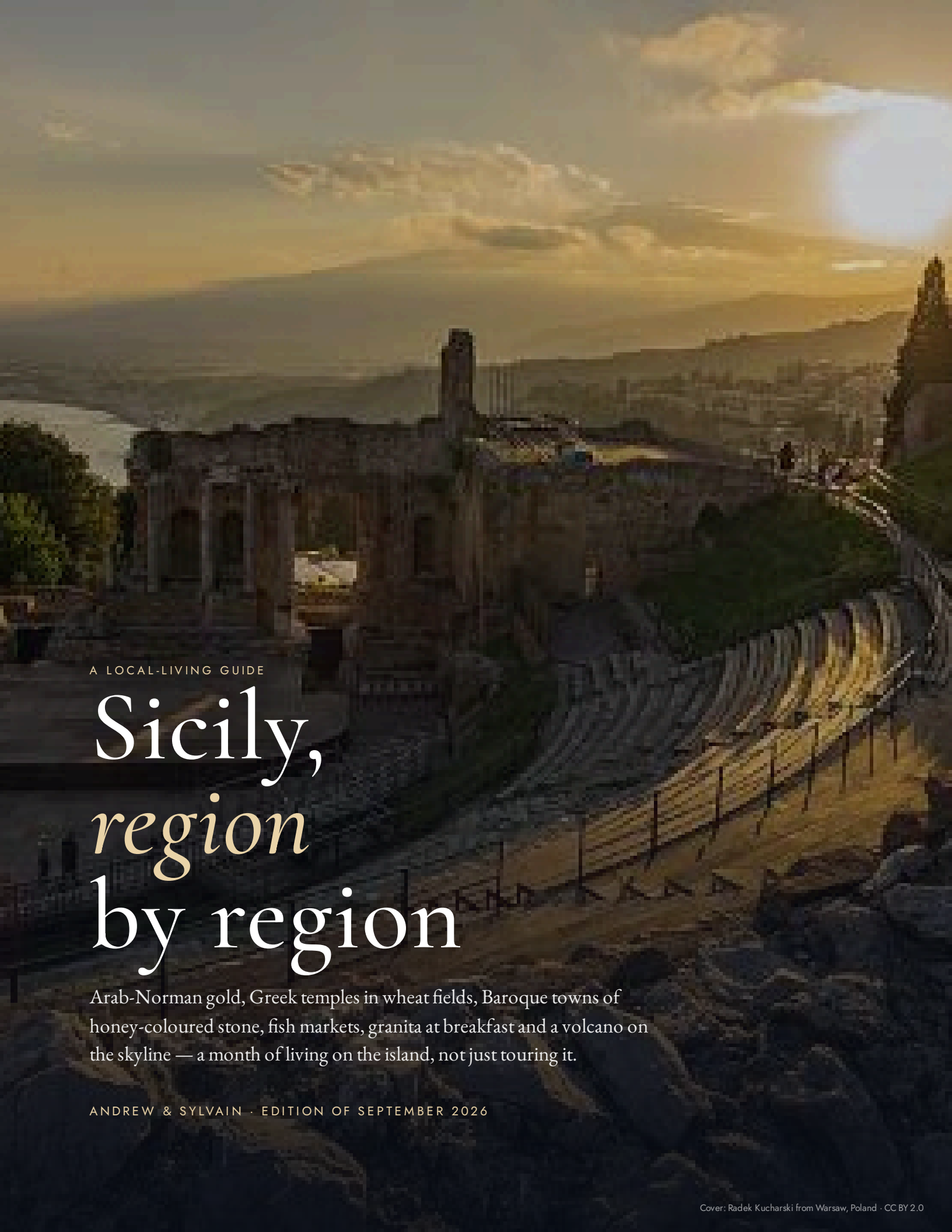




A LOCAL-LIVING GUIDE

Sicily, *region* by region

Arab-Norman gold, Greek temples in wheat fields, Baroque towns of honey-coloured stone, fish markets, granita at breakfast and a volcano on the skyline — a month of living on the island, not just touring it.

ANDREW & SYLVAIN · EDITION OF SEPTEMBER 2026

The regions

Sicily is big — about 280 km from Trapani to Messina — so this guide works in two halves: Palermo and the west, then Syracuse, the Baroque south-east, Catania, Etna and Taormina. Each chapter opens with its own map, and every numbered bubble matches an entry in the listings. The islands and Malta are extensions at the end.



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Seasons, closures & tickets

When to go

October is superb: 20–25°C days, a sea still around 22°C, the grape and olive harvests. November cools to 16–20°C, with short heavy showers. April–May bring wildflowers and orange blossom; July–August are 32–40°C and crowded. Watch for the *scirocco*, a hot dusty wind from Africa that turns the sky yellow.

Closures & rhythm

Shops and churches close for the *riposo*, roughly 13:00–16:30. Many museums close Monday or Sunday afternoon; restaurants close one day a week and dinner starts at 20:00. Holidays: 1 Nov, 8 Dec, 25–26 Dec, 6 Jan; Ferragosto (15 Aug) empties the cities and fills the beaches.

Tickets & free Sundays

There is no island-wide pass. Regional sites — Valley of the Temples (€14), Neapolis (€14), Segesta, Selinunte, Villa del Casale, the Palermo museums — are **free on the first Sunday** of the month (and packed). Book the big ones on CoopCulture; church sites like the Cappella Palatina and Monreale are separate.

Money & tipping

Cards work almost everywhere, but carry cash for markets, bars and buses. A *coperto* (cover, €1.50–3) is normal; tipping is rounding up or 5–10% for good service. An espresso at the bar is about €1.20 — more at a table.

Language & safety

A little Italian goes far; learn *amunì* (let's go) and *talìa* (look!). Sicily is safe; mind bags in Palermo's and Catania's markets and never leave anything visible in a parked car, especially at beaches and archaeological parks.

Entry for Canadians

No visa: Schengen rules, 90 days in any 180. The EU's biometric Entry/Exit System is fully live since April 2026 — fingerprints and a photo at first entry. ETIAS (€20) has slipped to 2027; check before any 2027 trip.



A Palermo street — Berthold Werner · CC BY-SA 4.0

This autumn: Bronte pistachio festival 2–4 Oct · Zafferana's Ottobrata every Sunday in October · Segesta and Selinunte shorten hours from 25–26 Oct · Erice cable car closed 3 Nov–4 Dec · Santa Lucia in Syracuse 13 Dec · Aeolian and Egadi ferries switch to winter timetables.

Trains, buses & a car for the corners

Airports

Palermo (PMO): Trinacria Express train to Palermo Centrale in about an hour (about €7), or the Prestia e Comandè bus to Politeama; a taxi is about €45. Catania (CTA): Alibus to the centre about every 25 minutes (about €4), and direct buses to Taormina and Syracuse. From Montreal, connect via Rome or another European hub.

Buses

Regional companies fill the gaps: Cuffaro/SAIS Palermo–Agrigento (2 h), Segesta Palermo–Trapani, Interbus Catania–Syracuse–Noto, Etna Trasporti Catania–Taormina, and one AST bus a day up Etna. Sunday service is thin.

Islands & the mainland

Liberty Lines hydrofoils: Milazzo–Aeolian Islands (1–2 h), Trapani–Egadi (30 min). Winter timetables from October and cancellations in rough seas — keep a spare day. Ferries cross the Strait of Messina around the clock.

Trains

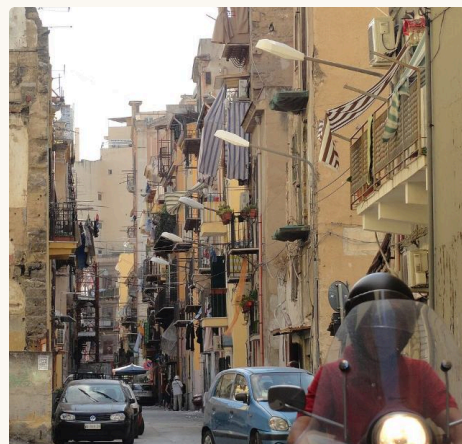
Trenitalia regional trains are cheap and scenic along the coasts: Palermo–Cefalù (about 1 h, €6), Catania–Taormina (45 min), Catania–Syracuse (1 h 10). Palermo–Catania is being rebuilt — the bus (2 h 40) is usually easier until about 2028.

A car for some days

Rent one for the Baroque towns, Selinunte, the Madonie and Etna — not for Palermo, Ortigia or Taormina. Beware the camera-enforced **ZTL** zones in Palermo, Ortigia, Taormina and Cefalù (fines arrive months later). Take zero-excess insurance; the A19 is toll-free, the coastal A18/A20 cheap tolls.

Malta

Virtu Ferries' catamaran runs Pozzallo–Valletta in about 1 h 45 — an easy 2–3 night extension, with your Malta guide already in the Travel folder.



Everyday Palermo, by scooter — l0da_ralta · CC BY 2.0

LGBTQ+ Sicily

The climate

Italy has had civil unions since 2016; there's no marriage, and a Canadian same-sex marriage is recognised as a civil union (next of kin in hospital, for example). Palermo and Catania are relaxed — couples in the historic centres rarely get a second look — and Palermo calls itself “the city of rights”. Inland villages are more Catholic: courteous, but keep affection discreet.

Catania & Taormina

In Catania, sit on the Alessi steps at Nievski, a queer-friendly pub-trattoria, or try Hasta Siempre and Buio; Le Capannine at La Playa is the gay beach. Taormina drew gay artists and writers from the 1890s — von Gloeden's photographs, then Gide, Capote and Tennessee Williams; Morgana is the chic garden bar today.

History & community

Arcigay, Italy's national LGBT association, was born in Palermo in 1980 after the murder of a young couple in Giarre (told in the film *Stranizza d'amuri*); a plaque to Giorgio and Toni stands in Bagheria. The Sicilia Queer Filmfest fills the Cantieri alla Zisa in late May.

Palermo

Exit Drinks on Piazza San Francesco di Paola has been the gay bar since 1996 — an afternoon café under parasols that turns to drag and DJ nights. In June 2026 Via Argenteria in the Vucciria became Sicily's first official **Gay Street**, with an info point and queer-run shops.

Pride

Palermo Pride is one of Italy's largest (2026: 20 June); Catania's was 27 June, Syracuse's 18 July, the Aeolian Islands' 6 June — and Agrigento held its first, officially backed Pride on 29 August 2026. 2027 dates are not yet announced; expect June–July.

Relaxed favourites

A late-afternoon spritz at Exit Drinks in Palermo; an evening on the Alessi steps at Nievski in Catania; sunset cocktails at Morgana in Taormina, then a walk past Casa Cuseni and the von Gloeden sites.

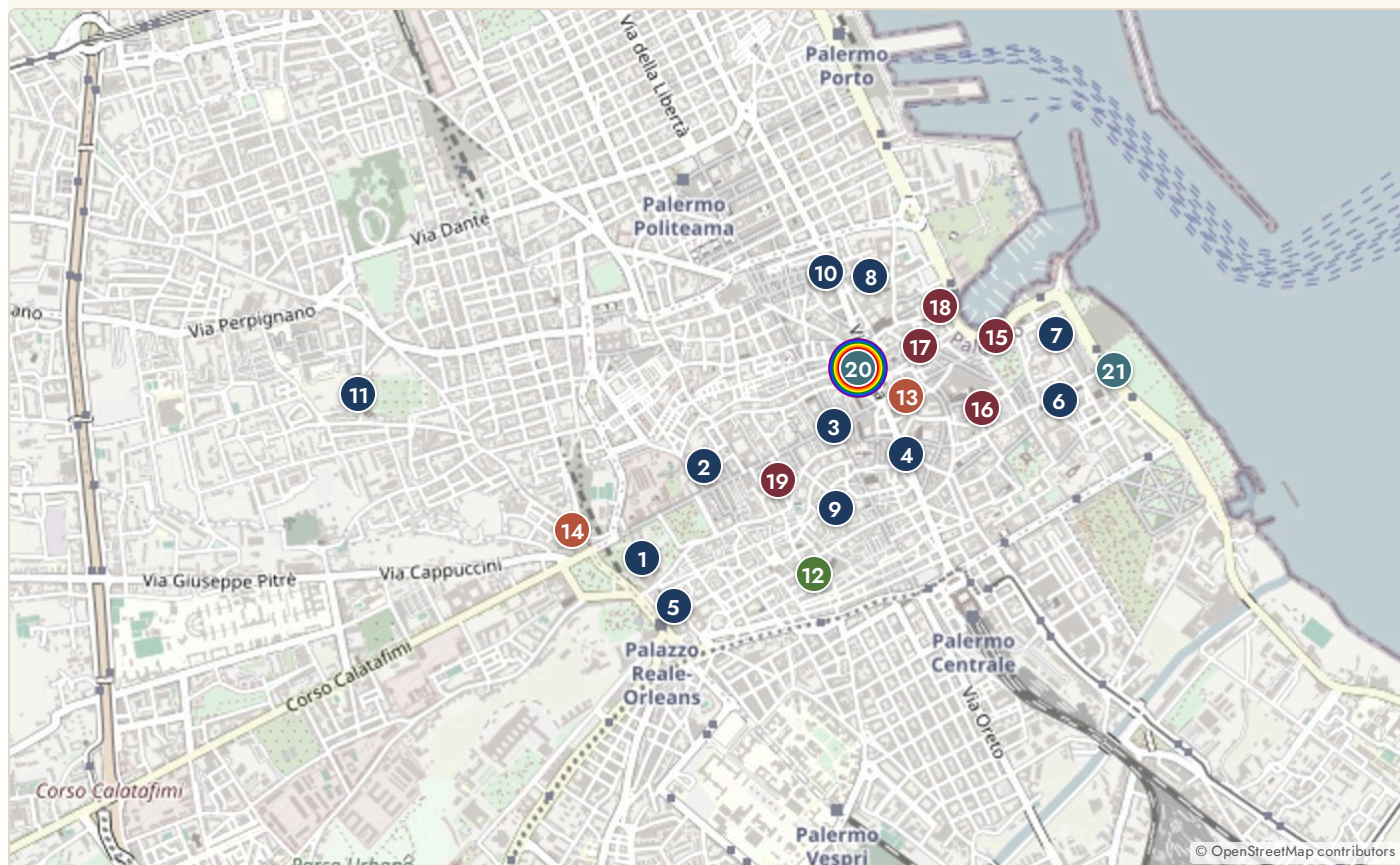


Pride in Sicily — Dedda71 · CC BY-SA 4.0

Throughout this guide, the  badge and rainbow-ringed map pins mark gay and LGBTQ+-friendly places, including a few quiet, well-known gay beaches.

I Palermo: the Old City

The four old quarters meet at the Quattro Canti: a layered city of Arab-Norman gold, Baroque stucco, peeling palazzi and shouting street markets. Live it like a local — coffee standing at the bar, the market by 10:00, a church or oratory before lunch, and the evening stroll on pedestrian Via Maqueda. The new Gay Street is in the Vucciria.

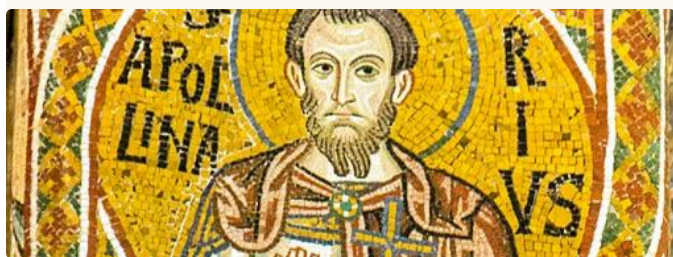


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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Palazzo dei Normanni & Cappella Palatina** — Roger II's 1140s chapel is the island's supreme mosaic interior, under a carved Fatimid wooden ceiling. €19 with the royal apartments (Mon, Thu–Sat 8:30–16:30; Sun to 12:30); chapel only about €15.50 on Tue–Wed. Go at opening; cover shoulders and knees.
- 2 **Cathedral & rooftops** — The church is free; the paid areas hold the royal tombs of Frederick II and Roger II, the treasury (Constance of Aragon's crown) and the roofs. Do the roofs late on a Saturday for golden light over the domes.
- 3 **Quattro Canti & Piazza Pretoria** — The Baroque crossroads of the two main streets, and a block away the Florentine fountain whose nudes earned it the name “Square of Shame”. Best early, or after 22:00 when it's floodlit and empty.
- 4 **La Martorana & San Cataldo** — Twin Arab-Norman churches: the Martorana's mosaic of Christ crowning King Roger (€2, mornings), and San Cataldo's three red domes (€2.50). The Martorana nuns gave their name to marzipan fruit.

- 5 **San Giovanni degli Eremiti** — Five pink domes over a bare Norman church and a cloister garden of citrus and roses — the calmest half-hour in Palermo. €8; daily.
- 6 **Palazzo Abatellis** — Carlo Scarpa's museum in a late-Gothic palace: the vast *Triumph of Death* fresco and Antonello da Messina's *Annunciata*. €10; closed Monday.
- 7 **Palazzo Butera** — A Kalsa palace restored as a living art house, antiques beside contemporary work, with a terrace on the old sea wall. Tue–Sun 10:00–20:00, €10; the €19 Operart pass adds a Teatro Massimo tour.
- 8 **Serpotta's oratories** — Giacomo Serpotta's white stucco putti at Santa Cita and the Rosario in San Domenico (with Van Dyck's Madonna), and at San Lorenzo round the frame of the Caravaggio stolen by the Mafia in 1969. About €6 each; closed Tuesday.
- 9 **Chiesa del Gesù (Casa Professa)** — The Jesuits' church, covered floor to vault in inlaid coloured marble. €2 (€6 with the museum); on the edge of Ballarò.
- 10 **Museo Salinas** — The Selinunte temple sculptures and the Palermo Stone in a glass-roofed cloister — see it before your Selinunte day. €8; closed Monday.
- 11 **La Zisa & the Capuchin Catacombs** — William I's 12th-century pleasure palace with its cooling fountain room (€8, closed Monday); nearby, 8,000 dressed-up mummies in the Capuchin Catacombs (about €5, no photos).



Andrea Schaffer · CC BY 4.0

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 12 **Ballarò, Il Capo & the Vucciria** — Ballarò is the loudest — vendors “singing” their prices, swordfish heads, *tenerumi* greens; Il Capo is fishier and calmer; both best Mon–Sat 8:00–13:00. The Vucciria is now an evening scene of grills and bars. Eat *panelle*, *crocchè* and boiled octopus at the stalls.

CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 13 **I Segreti del Chiostro** — The Santa Caterina convent's revived nuns' pastry shop: cannoli, “minne di Sant'Agata”, pistachio “trionfo di gola”. Add the church and dome terraces (€10) for the best view of Piazza Bellini.
- 14 **Cappello, Cappadonia & Stagnitta** — Cappello invented the seven-layer *setteveli* cake; Cappadonia has Gambero Rosso's top gelato rating (Bronte pistachio); Casa Stagnitta roasts coffee for granita with brioche.



Alessandro Cataldo · CC BY-SA 3.0

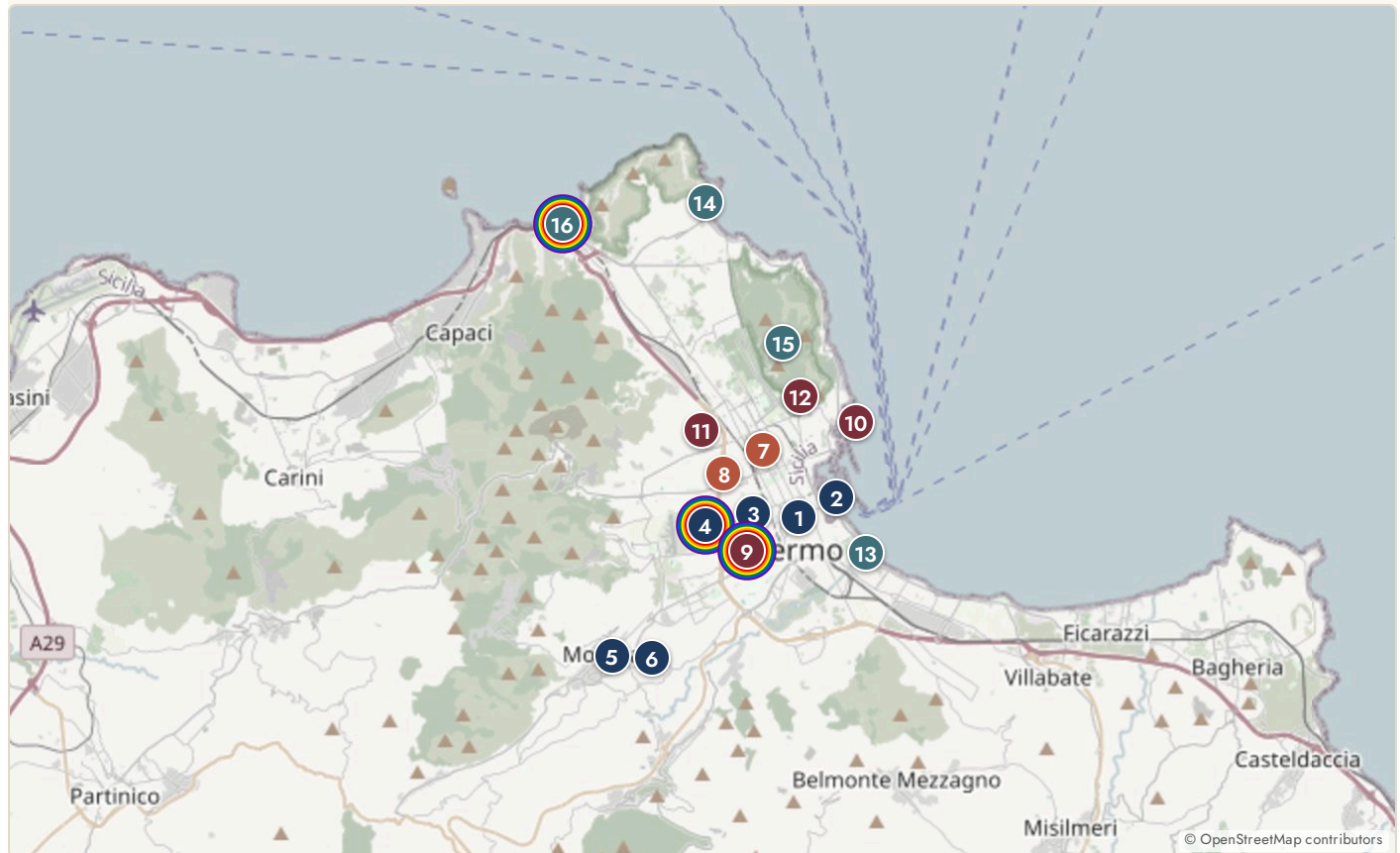
RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 15 **Street food: spleen, panelle, arancine** — Porta Carbone by the Cala harbour for *pane ca' meusa* (spleen bun — “schietta” plain, or “maritata” with cheese); Franco u Vastiddaru near Piazza Marina for panelle rolls; Ke Palle on Via Maqueda for arancine.
- 16 **Antica Focacceria San Francesco** — Open since 1834 opposite San Francesco, famous for refusing to pay the Mafia. Touristy but atmospheric outdoors: sfincione, arancina, caponata.
- 17 **Buatta & Ferro di Cavallo** — Buatta, one of Gambero Rosso's best trattorias, for sarde a beccafico and anelletti al forno (book); Ferro di Cavallo, red walls and saints behind the Teatro Massimo, cheap and fast — arrive at 12:30 or 19:30.
- 18 **Aja Mola & Gagini** — Two seafood rooms on Via dei Cassari: Aja Mola for crudo and natural wine; Gagini, reinvented in 2026 under chef Tiziana Francoforte, for a smart fish dinner.
- 19 **Mec** — Palermo's only Michelin star in 2026: Carmelo Trentacosti's tasting menus in a palazzo by the Cathedral full of vintage Apple computers. Book ahead.

- 20 **Via Argenteria — the Gay Street**  — Opened in June 2026 in the Vucciria and twinned with Barcelona's: an LGBTQ+ info point, vintage shop The Queen, booksellers, a gallery and trattorias.
- 21 **The Kalsa to the sea** — Palazzo Steri's Inquisition-cell graffiti and Guttuso's *Vucciria*, the giant ficus of the Giardino Garibaldi, the puppet museum, then the Foro Italico lawns at sunset.

2 Palermo: Libertà, Mondello & Monreale

North of the Teatro Massimo the city turns belle époque: wide Via Libertà, Liberty villas built on the Florio and Whitaker fortunes, Sunday pastry trays and aperitivo in big piazzas. The bus runs on to Mondello's turquoise bay; Monreale's gold mosaics are 30 minutes up the hill. Palermo's gay bar is here, by the Politeama.



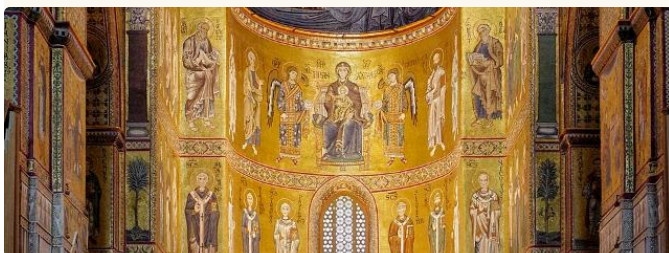
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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Teatro Massimo** — Italy's largest opera house (1897), where *The Godfather Part III* ends. 40-minute tours in English or French daily, about €14; better still, book a performance.
- 2 **Politeama & the Sinfonica** — The Pompeian-red triumphal arch between old and new Palermo, home of the Sicilian Symphony — a concert costs far less than the opera. The piazza is the Sunday-evening meeting point.
- 3 **Villa Malfitano Whitaker** — The English wine family's Liberty villa and seven hectares of exotic gardens. €15 (€25 with Mozia); Mon–Sat by phone booking only, minimum four people.
- 4 **Cantieri Culturali alla Zisa**  — A former factory turned arts complex — cinema, galleries and home of the Sicilia Queer Filmfest in late May and the Pride evening party.

5 Monreale Cathedral — About 6,400 m² of 12th-century gold mosaics telling the whole Bible. Church free (Mon–Sat 9:00–12:45 and 14:00–16:45; Sunday afternoons only); roofs and treasury extra. AMAT bus 389 from Piazza Indipendenza, or a taxi.

6 Monreale Cloister — 228 twin columns, every pair different, and an Arab fountain in the corner. €8; Mon–Sat 9:00–19:00, Sun to 13:30; free first Sunday. Then the belvedere over the Conca d'Oro.



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CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

7 Pasticceria Costa — The Libertà locals' Sunday pastry-tray shop: cassata, cannoli filled to order, brioche col tuppo for gelato.

8 Gelato: Ficus & La Vela — Ficus near Villa Malfitano for unusual and boozy flavours; La Vela at Arenella for sorbets on the way to Mondello.

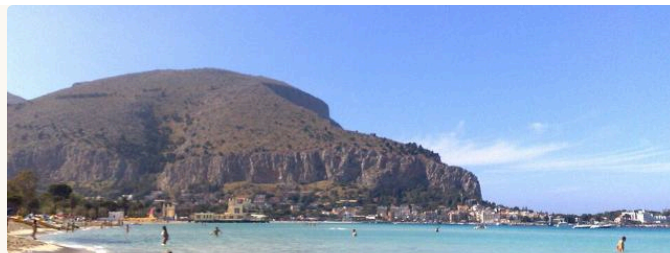
RESTAURANTS & BARS

9 Exit Drinks  — Palermo's gay bar since 1996: coffee and cake under parasols from the afternoon, then theme nights, drag and DJs; the same team runs Saturday club nights at La Fabric.

10 Enoteca Picone & Trattoria Corona — Picone, a historic wine shop pouring Etna, Vittoria and Pantelleria by the glass; Corona nearby for spaghetti with sea urchin in season.

11 Osteria Mercede — A different fish menu every day — ask what came in. Book.

12 Villa Igiea terrace — The Florios' Liberty grand hotel on the Acquasanta seafront: a sunset Negroni on the terrace over the marina, no need to stay.



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WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

13 Via Libertà & the Giardino Inglese — Plane-tree-lined palazzi, Basile's fairy-tale Villino Florio, and a 19th-century park with a kiosk bar — the area for local fashion shopping.

14 Mondello — A white-sand bay between two mountains, with a 1910s Liberty bathhouse on piles. Stroll the promenade, eat fried seafood at the kiosks, swim in September–October when it empties. Bus from Politeama or a taxi.

15 Monte Pellegrino & Santa Rosalia — The patron saint's dripping cave-church (free, daily) on the headland Goethe called the most beautiful in the world; huge views over the Conca d'Oro.

16 Capo Gallo & Barcarello  — Rocky coves in the Capo Gallo reserve, 30 minutes' walk on the Spartivento path — Palermo's naturist and gay-friendly swimming spot.

3 Cefalù & the Madonie

A fishing town squeezed between a huge limestone rock and a sandy beach, with Sicily's most perfect Norman cathedral in the middle, an hour from Palermo by train. Behind it the Madonie mountains rise to almost 2,000 m: stone hill villages, manna-ash groves, porcini and black pork. You'll want the car for the mountains.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Cefalù Cathedral** — Roger II's fortress-cathedral (from 1131), with the 1148 Christ Pantocrator mosaic — arguably the finest face of Christ in Byzantine art. Timed itineraries (towers, terraces, cloister, treasury) on duomocefalù.it.
- 2 **Museo Mandalisca** — A baron's cabinet of curiosities whose star is Antonello da Messina's *Portrait of an Unknown Man*, with his sly smile — and a Greek vase of a tuna seller. About €6–8, daily.

- 3 **Castello dei Ventimiglia** — A 14th-century castle-museum with a gilded Serpotta-school chapel; Castelbuono still collects rubbish by donkey.



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CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 4 **Graniteria Amorelli** — Fruit granita with barely any sugar — mulberry or lemon, with a brioche.
- 5 **Fiasconaro, Castelbuono** — Panettone made with Madonie manna (the sweet sap of the ash tree); the café does mannetto cake and gelato. 40 minutes from Cefalù.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **Osteria del Duomo** — Since 1979, with tables facing the cathedral steps: raw fish, tuna, pasta with bottarga.
- **Pasta a taianu** — Cefalù's own dish — pasta baked in a clay pot with fried aubergine, pork and beef ragù and pecorino, traditionally for Good Friday. Taverna Tinchitè and La Botte serve it.
- 7 **Qualia & Cortile Pepe** — The contemporary tables: Qualia's Nordic-meets-Sicilian cooking (house miso and bottarga) and Michelin-listed Cortile Pepe with its own organic garden.
- 8 **Nangalarruni, Castelbuono** — Peppe Carollo's mountain cooking: porcini in autumn, black pig, local cheeses and a big cellar.



Filippo Piazza · CC BY-SA 3.0

WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 9 **Lavatoio Medievale & the harbour** — Curved steps down to Arab-era wash basins fed by a spring, then Porta Pescara and the old harbour for the classic view of houses rising straight from the sea.
- 10 **La Rocca & the Temple of Diana** — A stepped path past Norman walls to a megalithic temple and castle ruins 270 m up. 1–1.5 hours; go early with water (small fee).
- 11 **Sunset on the rocks** — Bordomari's cocktail bar on the rocks below the old town; arrive 45 minutes before sunset.
- 12 **Spiaggia delle Dune**  — Quiet dunes west of town at Ogliastrillo, known as Cefalù's gay-friendly beach; the town beach and Kalura cove are the others, swimmable into October.

- 13 **Petralia Soprana & Gangi** — Two of Sicily's "most beautiful villages" at over 1,000 m — stone lanes, a belvedere over half the island and churches full of painted statues. Bring a sweater.
- 14 **Piano Battaglia & Gibilmanna** — Beech woods, mountain pastures and the rare Nebrodi fir, with easy walks; stop at the Gibilmanna sanctuary above Cefalù for the view.

4 Trapani, Erice & the Far West

The west faces Africa: couscous, Phoenician islands, windmills over pink salt pans, fortified Marsala cellars and Greek temples standing alone in wheat fields. Base yourselves two or three nights in Trapani with the car; the sunsets over the Egadi from the salt pans are the reason to stay.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Erice** — A walled medieval town 750 m up, with the Castle of Venus and views to the Egadi and towards Tunisia. The cable car is €9 up (€15 return) — closed 3 Nov–4 Dec 2026, when you drive or take the AST bus. Often in fog: bring a layer.
- 2 Mozia (Motya)** — A Phoenician island-city in the lagoon, bought by Joseph Whitaker; its museum holds the marble *Motya Charioteer*. €12 plus the 10-minute boat; museum closes 14:00–15:00.
- 3 Mazara del Vallo** — The bronze *Dancing Satyr*, hauled up in a fishing net in 1998 (€8, daily), then the tiled alleys of the Kasbah and Mazara's famous red prawns.
- 4 Segesta** — An unfinished Doric temple alone on a hillside, and a hilltop theatre facing the sea. €14; 9:00–17:00 to 24 Oct, then 9:00–15:30. Shuttle or a 20-minute walk to the theatre.
- 5 Selinunte** — Europe's largest archaeological park: rebuilt Temple E, fallen column drums and an acropolis above a sandy beach. €17 (€25 with the internal shuttle — worth it); free first Sunday. Lunch in Marinella.



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CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 6 Maria Grammatico, Erice** — Maria learned her craft in an Erice convent orphanage (her memoir is *Bitter Almonds*). Eat a warm *genovese* and take away marzipan fruit.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 Cantina Siciliana** — The couscous address: hand-rolled semolina steamed and soaked in saffron fish broth, with more broth on the side.
- 8 Salamureci** — Fresh *busiate* with Trapani pesto — almond, garlic, tomato and basil — topped with fried aubergine.
- 9 Pocho, Macari** — Marilù Terrasi has cooked couscous for 30-plus years on a terrace above the sea near San Vito Lo Capo's white beach. Book the sunset table.



tato grasso · CC BY-SA 3.0

SHOPPING & WINE

- 10 Marsala: Florio & Pellegrino** — Tuff-stone aisles holding six million litres of Marsala; tours booked online. Pellegrino pours Pantelleria passito too. Then Marsala's white-stone centre from Porta Garibaldi, where Garibaldi landed in 1860.

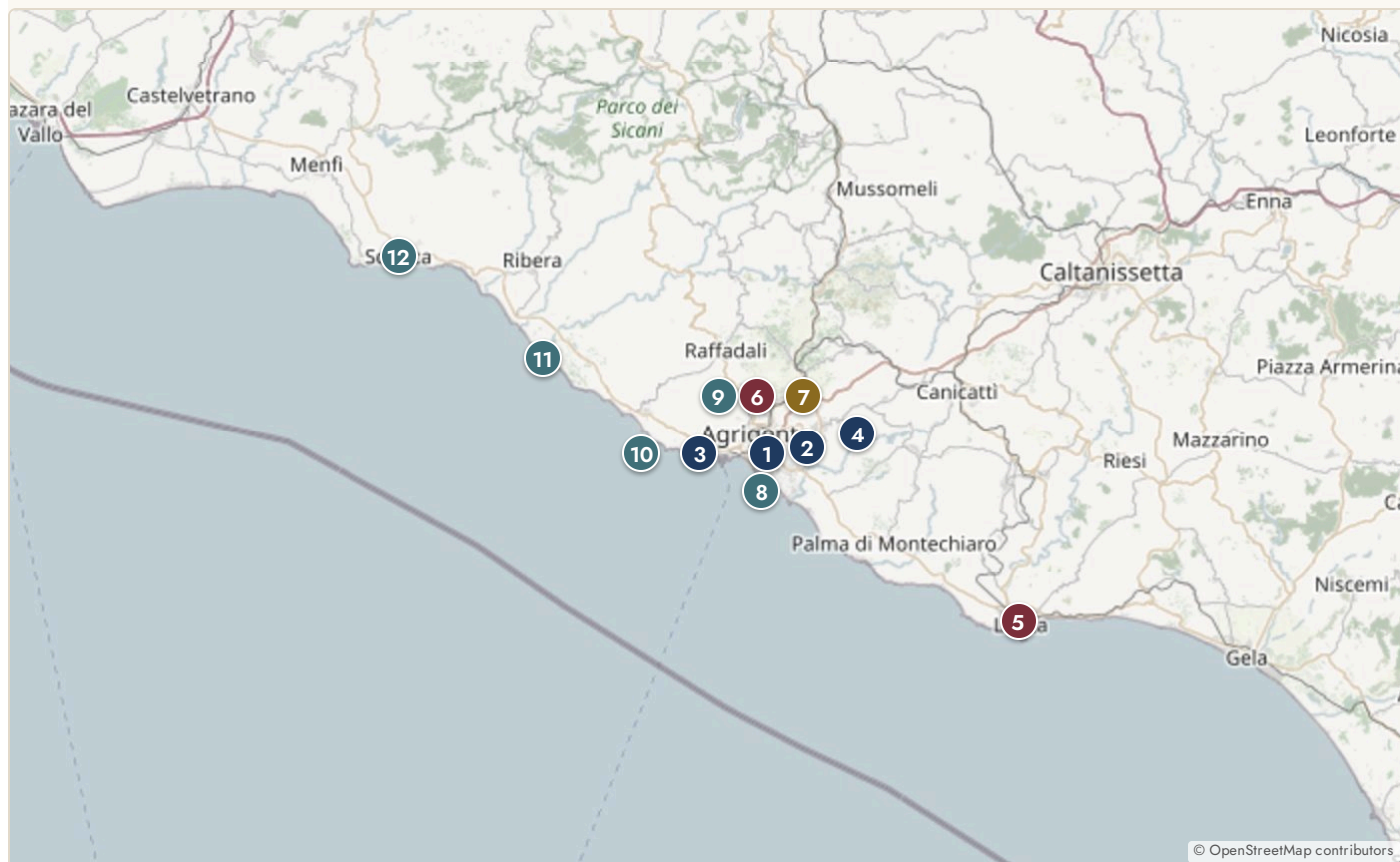
WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 11 Trapani old town** — The sickle-shaped peninsula: Baroque Via Garibaldi, the old Jewish quarter, the north sea walls to Torre di Ligny, and the Purgatorio church with the Misteri carried in the 24-hour Good Friday procession.

- 12 The salt road** — 30 km of salt pans south along the coast, flamingos in the WWF reserve at Nubia, and a restored windmill at Ettore e Inversa on the Stagnone lagoon. Come for sunset; buy fleur de sel.
- 13 Scopello & the Zingaro reserve** — A hamlet round an old courtyard, the tonnara among sea stacks below, and 7 km of car-free coast path with coves in the Zingaro reserve (about €5). No shade — two litres of water each.

5 Agrigento & the South Coast

A ridge above the finest run of Doric temples outside Greece, with almond and olive groves between the town and the sea. West lie the white marl cliffs of Realmonte and the ceramics port of Sciacca; east, Favara's art courtyards and a two-star table in Licata. Agrigento held its first Pride in August 2026 — a sign of a more open town.

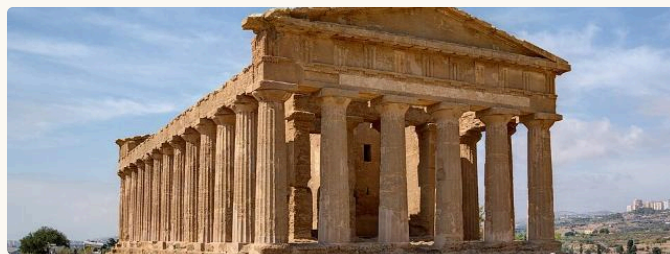


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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Valley of the Temples** — A 3 km ridge walk from the Temple of Juno past the near-intact Temple of Concordia to the fallen Temple of Zeus. €14 (+€3 surcharge to 31 Oct), 8:30–20:00; free first Sunday. Walk one way and taxi back.
- 2 Museo Archeologico Pietro Griffo** — The 7.6 m reassembled Telamon from the Temple of Zeus and superb Greek vases — go before the Valley. €19.20 combined.
- 3 Pirandello's house** — The Nobel playwright's birthplace in the countryside of Caos; his ashes lie under a rock near the pine he loved, facing the sea.

- 4 Farm Cultural Park, Favara** — Seven courtyards of an abandoned old town turned into a contemporary art and architecture hub — the best antidote to ancient ruins, 8 km from Agrigento.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 5 **La Madia, Licata** — Pino Cuttaia's two-star "memory" cooking — cuttlefish carbonara, the arancina he remembers. The destination dinner of the south coast; book weeks ahead.
- 6 **Osteria Expanificio & Kalòs** — A Michelin-listed former bakery with a square-side terrace, fair-priced seafood; Kalòs at the top of Via Atenea for a polished dinner with a view.

SHOPPING & WINE

- 7 **Santo Spirito convent sweets** — Cistercian nuns sell almond pastries and a sweet pistachio "couscous" through the doorbell — ring and wait.



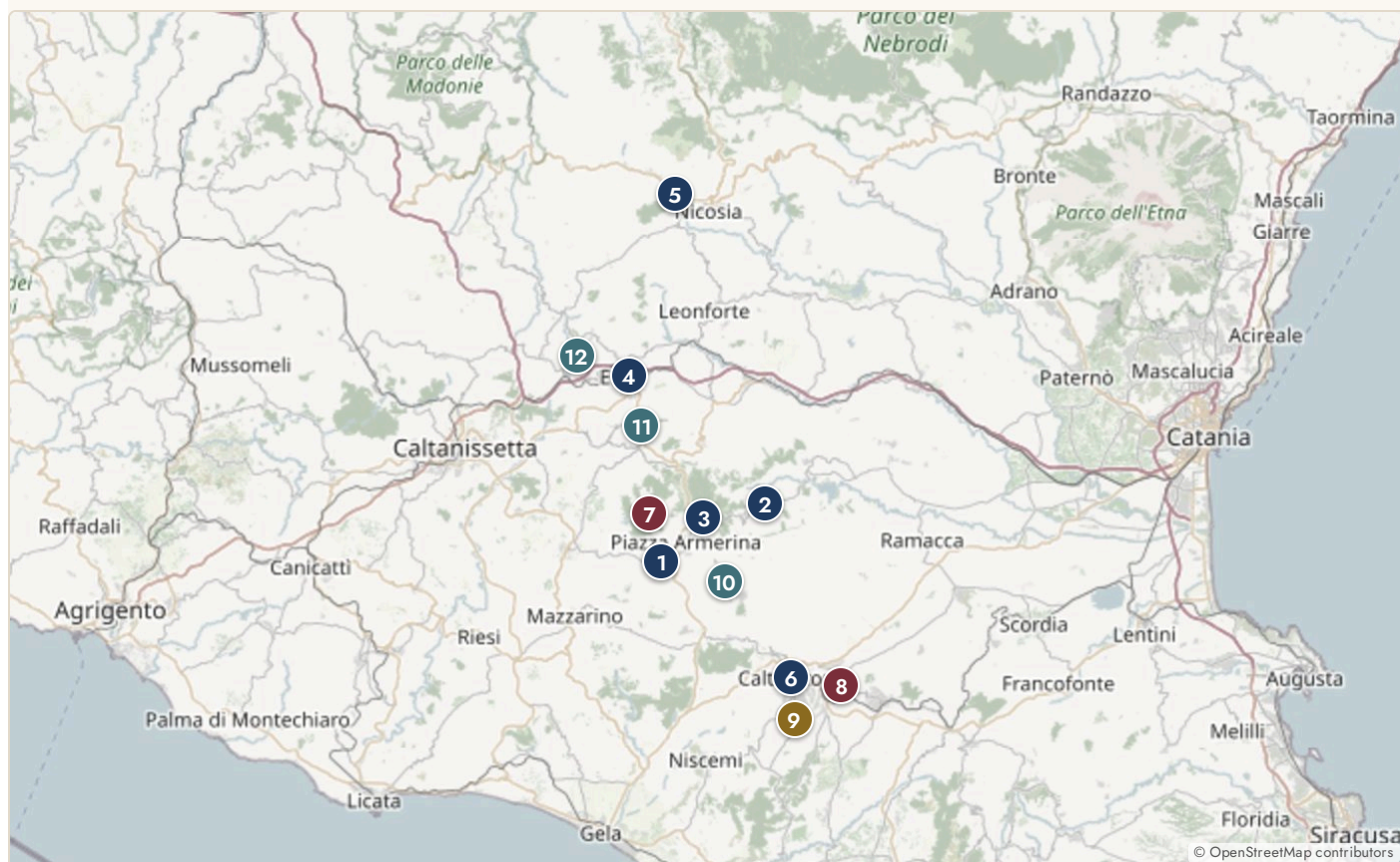
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WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 8 **Kolymbethra Garden** — A sunken FAI garden of citrus, olive and almond below the temples, watered by 5th-century BC tunnels; complete shade and autumn tangerines. €20 combined with the Valley.
- 9 **Via Atenea & the old town** — The pedestrian main street, stairs up to the cathedral and Santa Maria dei Greci, built on a temple whose columns show under the floor.
- 10 **Scala dei Turchi** — A dazzling white marl staircase above the sea. Since May 2026: €6, card only, on site, groups of 50 every 20 minutes (1,800 a day). Late afternoon light is best; the free view is from the beach below.
- 11 **Torre Salsa & Eraclea Minoa** — Six kilometres of empty WWF beach and gypsum cliffs, then a Greek theatre carved from marl on a headland above a pine-backed beach.
- 12 **Sciacca** — A fishing port stepped up a hillside, with maiolica workshops on Corso Vittorio Emanuele and fish at the harbour. The historic spa is closed; see Bentivegna's eerie carved heads at the Castello Incantato.

6 REGION The Heartland

The high wheat-and-sulphur plateau at the centre of the island: Enna, Italy's highest provincial capital, hill towns carved from rock, Roman mosaics at Piazza Armerina, a returned Greek goddess at Aidone and Caltagirone's tiled staircase. A car is essential; autumn brings mist, mushrooms and empty sites.



● Sights & Museums ● Cafés, Pastry & Gelato ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Wine ● Walks, Beaches & Hidden Corners
 🏳️‍🌈 LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Villa Romana del Casale** — About 3,500 m² of 4th-century mosaics seen from walkways — the “bikini girls”, the 60 m Great Hunt, Ulysses and the Cyclops. €14, daily 9:00–19:00.
- 2 **Morgantina** — A Greek-Sikel city with an agora, assembly steps and theatre on a ridge facing Etna — usually all yours.
- 3 **Aidone museum** — The 2.2 m Goddess of Morgantina (about 400 BC), returned by the Getty in 2011 with the Morgantina silver.
- 4 **Enna: the castle & the Rocca** — One of Sicily's largest medieval castles — climb the Pisan tower for Etna and the whole interior — and the Rocca di Cerere where the temple of Demeter stood. Often 8–10°C cooler than the coast.
- 5 **Sperlinga** — A castle carved largely from the rock above old cave houses, whose inscription recalls the town's refusal to join the Sicilian Vespers.
- 6 **Caltagirone's staircase** — 142 lava-stone steps, each riser faced with different hand-painted maiolica, lit with thousands of lamps on 24–25 July. Climb it at dusk anyway.



José Luiz · CC BY-SA 4.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 **Al Fogher** — Michelin-listed creative cooking in a former railway house — lamb, wild herbs, ricotta and local wheat. The best dinner in the heartland.
- 8 **Coria, Caltagirone** — One Michelin star for dishes reinterpreting the great Sicilian food writer Giuseppe Coria — good-value tasting menus.

SHOPPING & WINE

- 9 **Caltagirone ceramics** — The ceramics museum, temporarily in Palazzo Libertini, and workshops on every approach street.



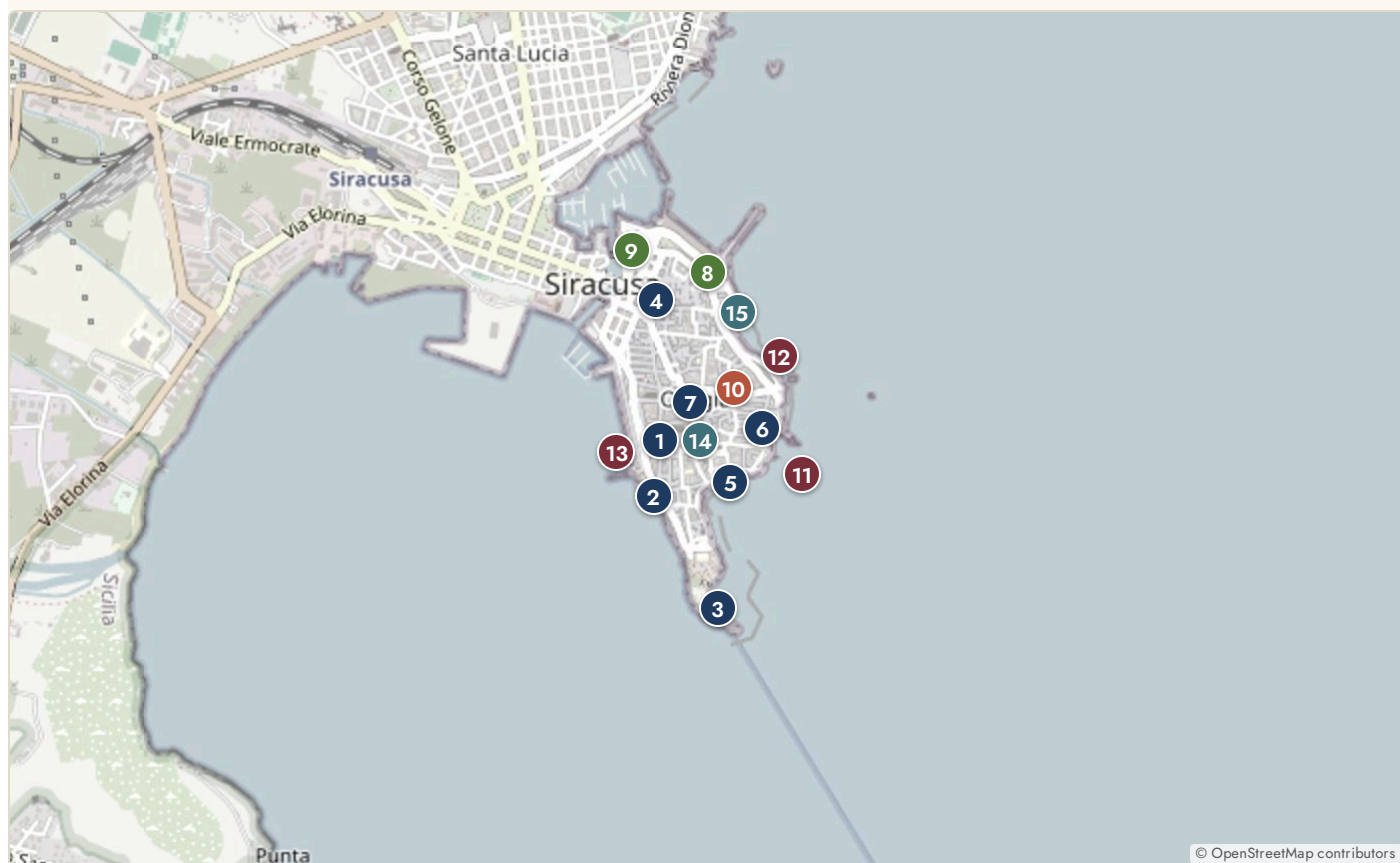
Michal Osmenda from Brussels, Belgium · CC BY-SA 2.0

WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 10 **Piazza Armerina** — A Baroque cathedral crowning a Norman-Lombard town where a northern Italian dialect survives.
- 11 **Lake Pergusa** — Where myth says Hades seized Persephone — a nature reserve with birdlife, oddly ringed by a motor-racing circuit.
- 12 **Calascibetta** — A honey-coloured Arab-Norman town facing Enna, with 300 rock-cut Bronze Age tombs on the hillside just outside.

7 Syracuse: Ortigia

A limestone island about 1 km long, joined to the mainland by two bridges and lived on for 2,700 years. Fishmongers shout on Via De Benedictis at 7:00, the Greek temple columns still hold up the cathedral, and most of it is pedestrian. You can walk it in 20 minutes — or spend a month finding new corners.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **The Duomo** — The 5th-century BC Doric columns of the Temple of Athena are built into the nave walls, fluting and all; the Baroque front came after 1693. A few euros; dress modestly.
- 2 **Fonte Aretusa** — A freshwater spring a few metres from the sea, with wild papyrus, ducks and mullet — the nymph Arethusa of myth. The sunset meeting point.
- 3 **Castello Maniace** — Frederick II's square fortress at the island's tip, with a vaulted Gothic hall and ramparts over the open sea; swim at Cala Rossa below.
- 4 **Temple of Apollo** — Sicily's oldest Doric temple (6th century BC), just over the bridge — the start of a first-day walk up Corso Matteotti to the Diana fountain.
- 5 **Palazzo Bellomo** — Antonello da Messina's 1474 *Annunciation*, Gagini sculpture and Sicilian silver in a Swabian palazzo. €8; Tue–Sat 9:00–19:00, Sun to 13:00.
- 6 **The Miqwè** — A Jewish ritual bath 18 m underground, hidden before the 1492 expulsion and rediscovered in the 1980s; guided visits from the Alla Giudecca hotel. Then walk Via della Giudecca.

- 7 Teatro dei Pupi** — The Vaccaro-Mauceri family's armoured marionettes clanging through Orlando and the paladins — 50 minutes, easy without Italian. Book on [liveticket.it](https://www.liveticket.it).



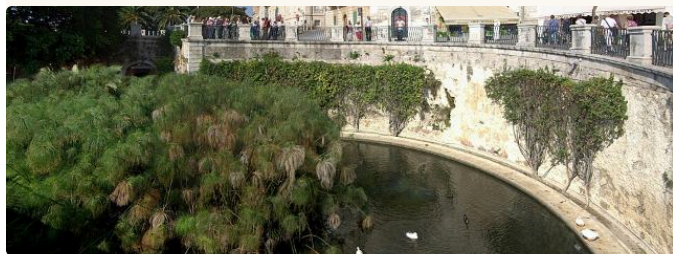
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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 8 Ortigia market** — Mon–Sat from 7:00 to early afternoon: swordfish, tuna, branch oregano, Avola almonds, Pachino tomatoes. Fried-seafood cones at La Lisca (€8–12). Caseificio Borderi's famous sandwiches have been closed for renovation since January 2026.
- 9 Fratelli Burgio** — A deli with tables at the market's edge: a board of Sicilian cheeses, salumi and caponata with Nero d'Avola — the long market lunch.

CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 10 Pasticceria Artale** — Almond granita and brioche for breakfast; cannoli filled to order.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 11 Cortile Spirito Santo** — Syracuse's first Michelin star, in a 17th-century courtyard: tasting menus from €120 (vegetarian) to €170. Closed Monday; book.
- 12 Don Camillo** — Since 1985, Sicilian seafood classics under 15th-century vaults; save room for dessert. Closed Sunday.
- 13 Regina Lucia** — Tables on Piazza Duomo — the farewell-night splurge.

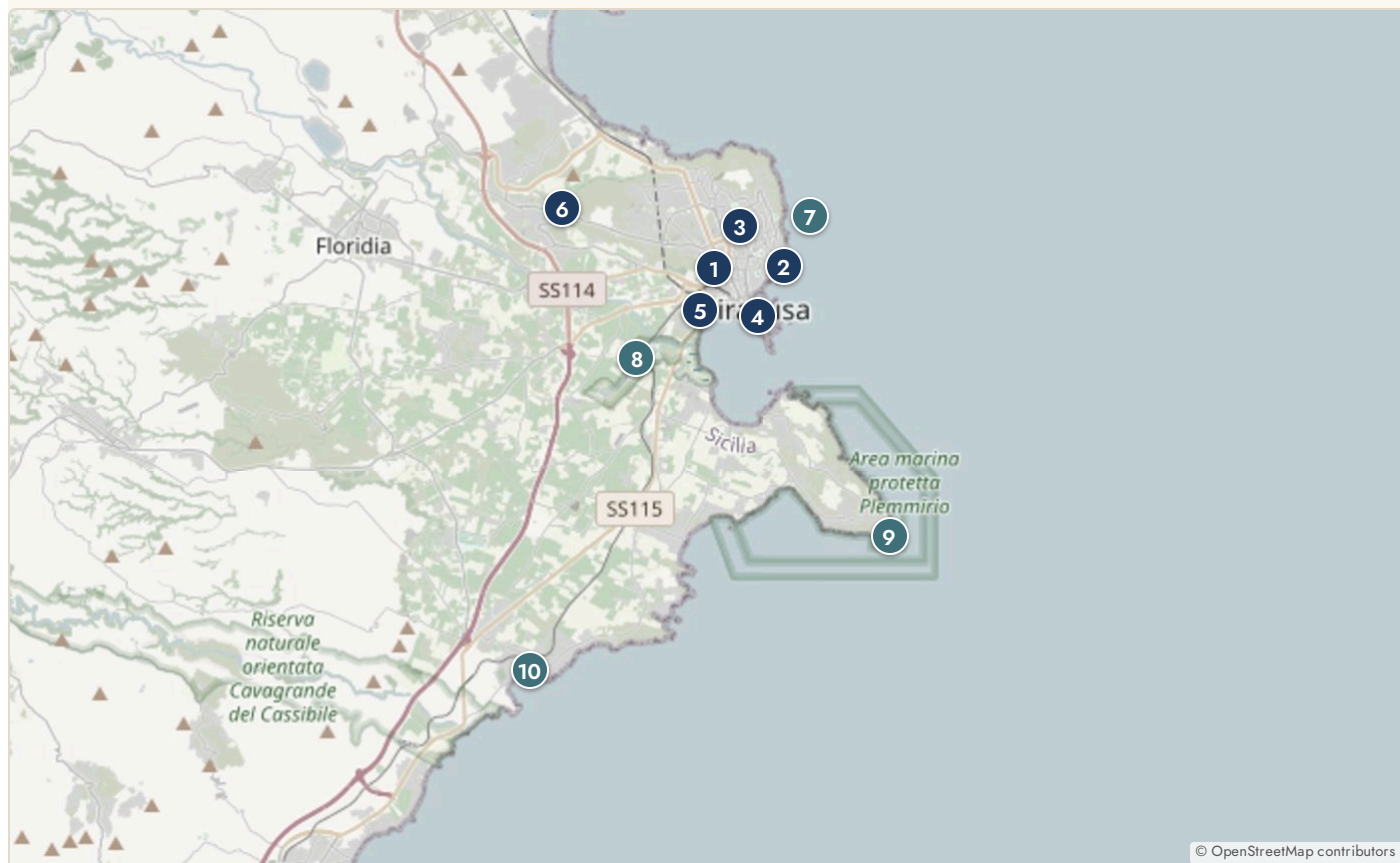
WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 14 Piazza Duomo** — Ortigia's white living room, best at 7:00 before the groups or after 22:00 when it glows. Coffee at a table and the evening passeggiata.
- 15 Forte Vigliena & the Lungomare di Levante** — A free wooden sea platform with ladders into deep clear water (June–September), then the east-side walk to Castello Maniace at dusk.

8 REGION

Syracuse: Neapolis & Plemmirio

Across the bridge lies the ancient city Cicero called the greatest and most beautiful of the Greek world: the theatre, a superb archaeology museum, catacombs second only to Rome's, and a Caravaggio in the church it was painted for. South of town, the Plemmirio peninsula and the papyrus-lined Ciane river offer wild swims and a slow boat.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Neapolis Archaeological Park** — The Greek theatre, the Ear of Dionysius in the Paradise quarry and the Roman amphitheatre. €14 (€18 with the Orsi museum); from 8:30, closing earlier each month into winter. Go at opening — no shade.
- 2 **Paolo Orsi Museum** — One of Europe's great archaeology museums: the Landolina Venus, Gorgon terracottas, coins upstairs. €10; Tue–Sat, closed Monday. Allow three hours.
- 3 **Catacombs of San Giovanni** — A 4th-century labyrinth of some 10,000 tombs and the crypt where St Paul is said to have preached. Guided only, €10; closed Monday.
- 4 **Caravaggio's *Burial of St Lucy*** — Painted in 1608 while on the run, back since 2020 in the church over Lucy's tomb. Free; closed during services. Her feast is 13 December.
- 5 **Madonna delle Lacrime** — A 74 m concrete cone (1994) for a plaster Madonna said to have wept in 1953 — love it or hate it.

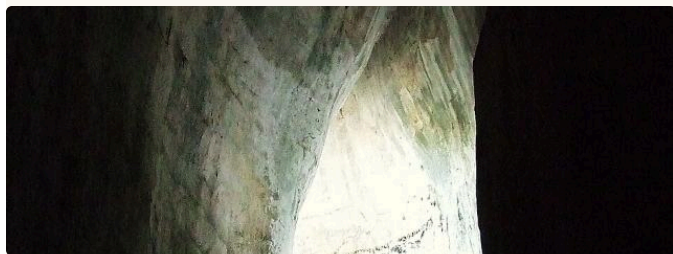
- 6 **Castello Eurialo** — Dionysius I's great fortress on the plateau, with tunnels, moats and views to Etna; few visitors, irregular hours — phone first.



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WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

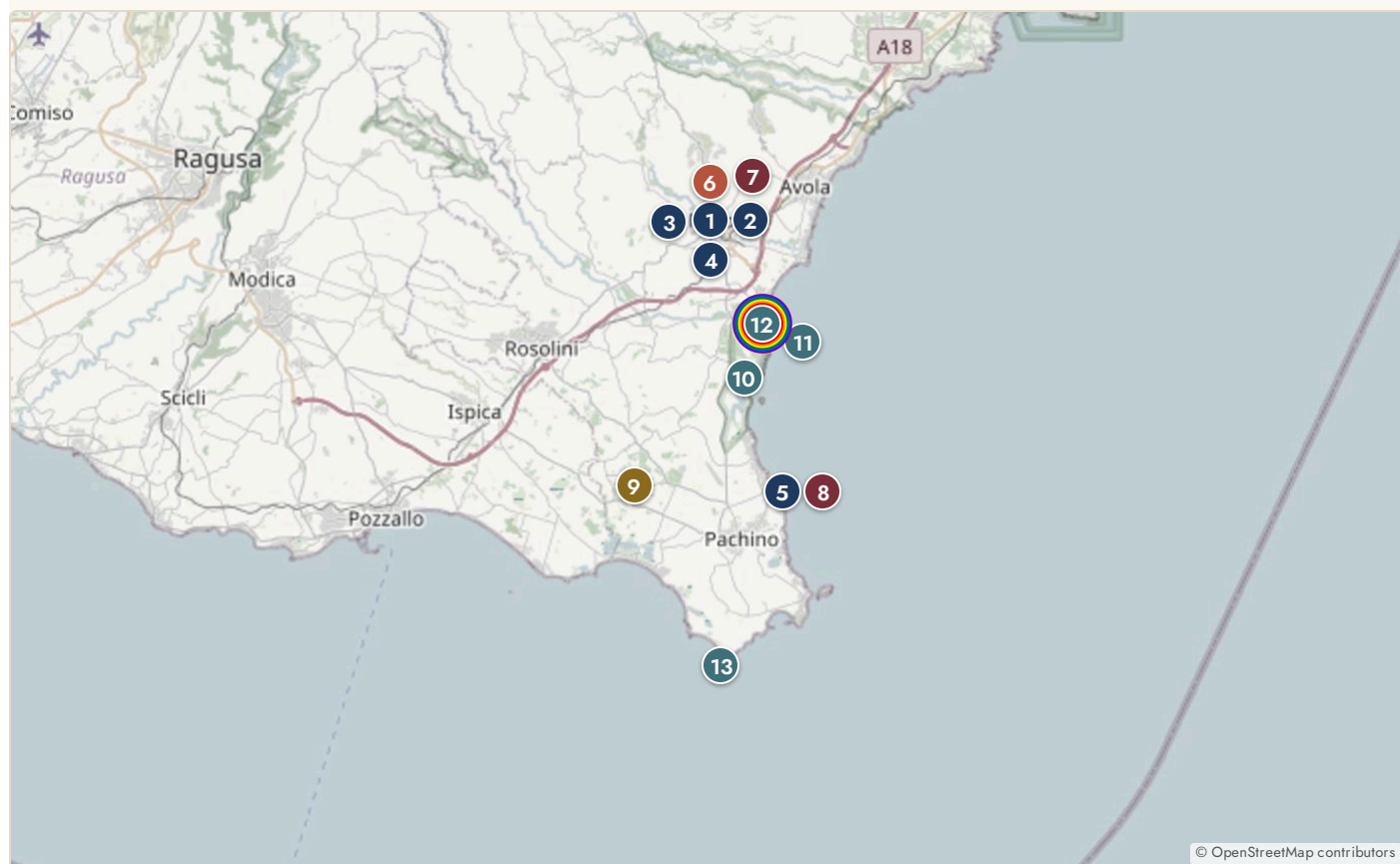
- 7 **Belvedere San Giacomo** — The sea terrace by the Capuchin quarry where Athenian prisoners were held in 413 BC — a free sunset walk from Ortigia.
- 8 **The Ciane papyrus boat** — Small boats from the Porto Grande up the river through tunnels of wild papyrus to the spring of the nymph Cyane — about two hours in season.
- 9 **Plemmirio** — A marine reserve 20 minutes south: a cliff path to the lighthouse, snorkelling off the rocks, and the Pillirina cove facing Ortigia. Calm days only; bring everything.
- 10 **Fontane Bianche** — Syracuse's white-sand crescent 18 km south — lovely in September and early October.



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9 Noto, Vendicari & Marzamemi

Noto was rebuilt from scratch after the 1693 earthquake as one Baroque stage set in honey-coloured stone. South of it, the Vendicari reserve has flamingos, a ruined tuna fishery and Sicily's best wild beaches; at the island's south-east tip, Marzamemi's tonnara square becomes a candle-lit dining room on summer nights.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Noto Cathedral** — The great staircase is Noto's front porch; the dome fell in 1996 and was rebuilt by hand, reopening in 2007.
- 2 **Palazzo Nicolaci** — Balconies on carved horses, sirens and lions; frescoed rooms inside. The street is carpeted with flowers for the Infiorata in mid-May.
- 3 **San Carlo bell tower** — Climb the narrow stair for the dome and rooftops in late-afternoon gold.
- 4 **Palazzo Ducezio** — The town hall's gilded hall of mirrors, and the jewel-box Teatro Tina di Lorenzo.

- 5 **Marzamemi** — A tuna-fishing hamlet round its tonnara square; shops for bottarga and tuna in oil. Quiet from November to March.



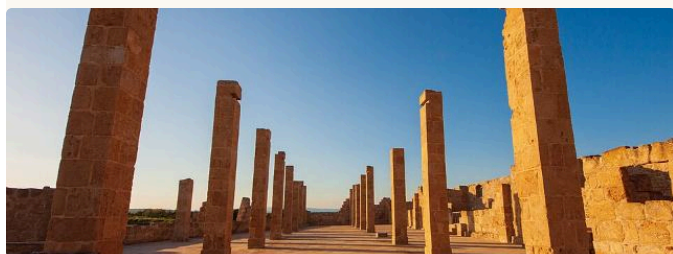
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CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 6 **Caffè Sicilia** — Corrado Assenza's historic pastry shop (of *Chefs Table*): almond granita with brioche, cassata, savoury-sweet preserves. Usually closed Monday.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 **Crocifisso** — Marco Baglieri's one-star "almost baroque" cooking in upper Noto. Dinner only; closed Wednesday.
- 8 **La Cialoma** — Lina Campisi's seafood trattoria on the piazza — tuna, pasta with bottarga, the catch of the day. Book a piazza table for sunset.



Gabriele Iuvara from La Spezia · CC BY-SA 2.0

SHOPPING & WINE

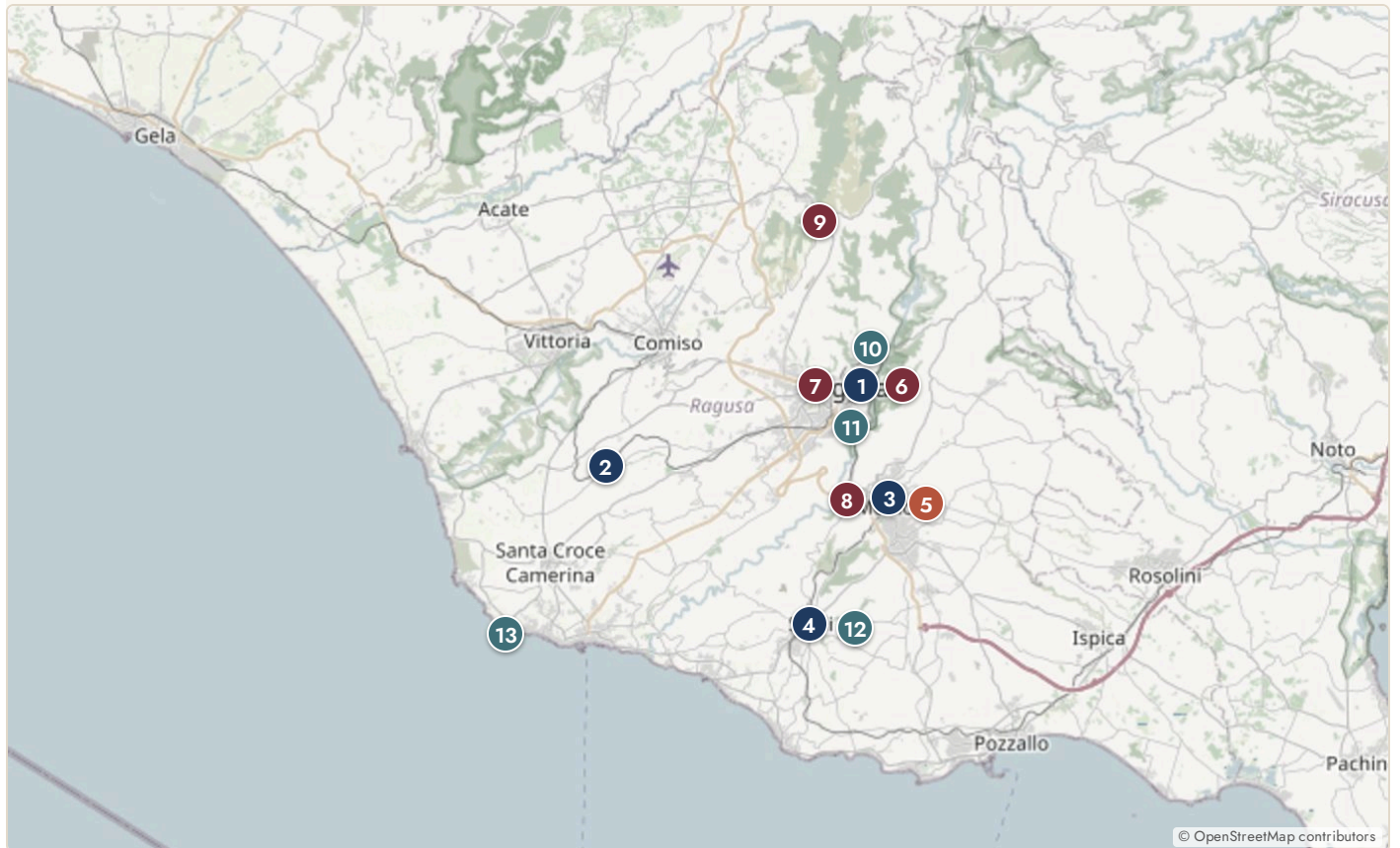
- 9 **Planeta Buonavini** — Planeta's Nero d'Avola estate between Noto and Pachino, with an old palmento; tastings and cooking by booking.

WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 10 **Vendicari reserve** — €3.50; five entrances off the SP19 and 500 m–1 km walks without shade. Flamingos in spring and autumn, a ruined tonnara and a Swabian tower.
- 11 **Calamosche** — A small sandy bay between two headlands — perhaps Sicily's most photographed beach. 1 km from its car park; no services.
- 12 **Marianelli**  — A quiet sandy beach inside the Vendicari reserve, well known as a gay and naturist beach, a short walk from the car park.
- 13 **Isola delle Correnti** — Sicily's southernmost point, where two seas meet off a lighthouse islet you can wade to on calm days.

IO Ragusa Ibla, Modica & Scicli

The inland Baroque towns of the Val di Noto spill down limestone gorges under one UNESCO listing — and the area is a food destination: two-star dining, Aztec-method chocolate, heroic pork. Montalbano fans will know the streets. A car is almost essential.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **San Giorgio, Ragusa Ibla** — Rosario Gagliardi's three-tier wedding-cake façade (1739–75), set at an angle at the top of a sloping piazza.
- 2 **Castello di Donnafugata** — A neo-Gothic country palace with period rooms and a stone labyrinth, 15 km out — in *The Leopard* and Montalbano. Daily 9:00–19:00.
- 3 **San Giorgio, Modica** — A towering façade at the top of 250 steps; continue up to the Pizzo belvedere over the gorge.

- 4 **Via Mormino Penna, Scicli** — One of Sicily's most beautiful streets; the town hall is Montalbano's "Commissariato" (visitable), and Palazzo Beneventano's masks are round the corner.



Dottorpeni · CC BY 2.0

CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 5 **Antica Dolceria Bonajuto** — Sicily's oldest chocolate maker (1880): grainy, cold-worked Modica chocolate with cinnamon or chili, and *'mpanatigghi* filled with beef and chocolate. Long midday break.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **Duomo — Ciccio Sultano** — Two Michelin stars, Sicily's reference table: tasting menus about €178–198, lunch about €75–85.
- 7 **Locanda Don Serafino** — One star in a dining room that looks carved from rock, with 2,880 wines. Closed Tuesday and Wednesday.
- 8 **Radici — L'Osteria di Accursio** — Accursio Craparo closed his starred restaurant and since 2025 cooks only here: ingredient-led Sicilian food at trattoria prices.
- 9 **Majore, Chiaramonte Gulfi** — “Here we magnify pork” since 1896: pork-sauce pasta and stuffed ribs for a long Sunday lunch in the “balcony of Sicily”.



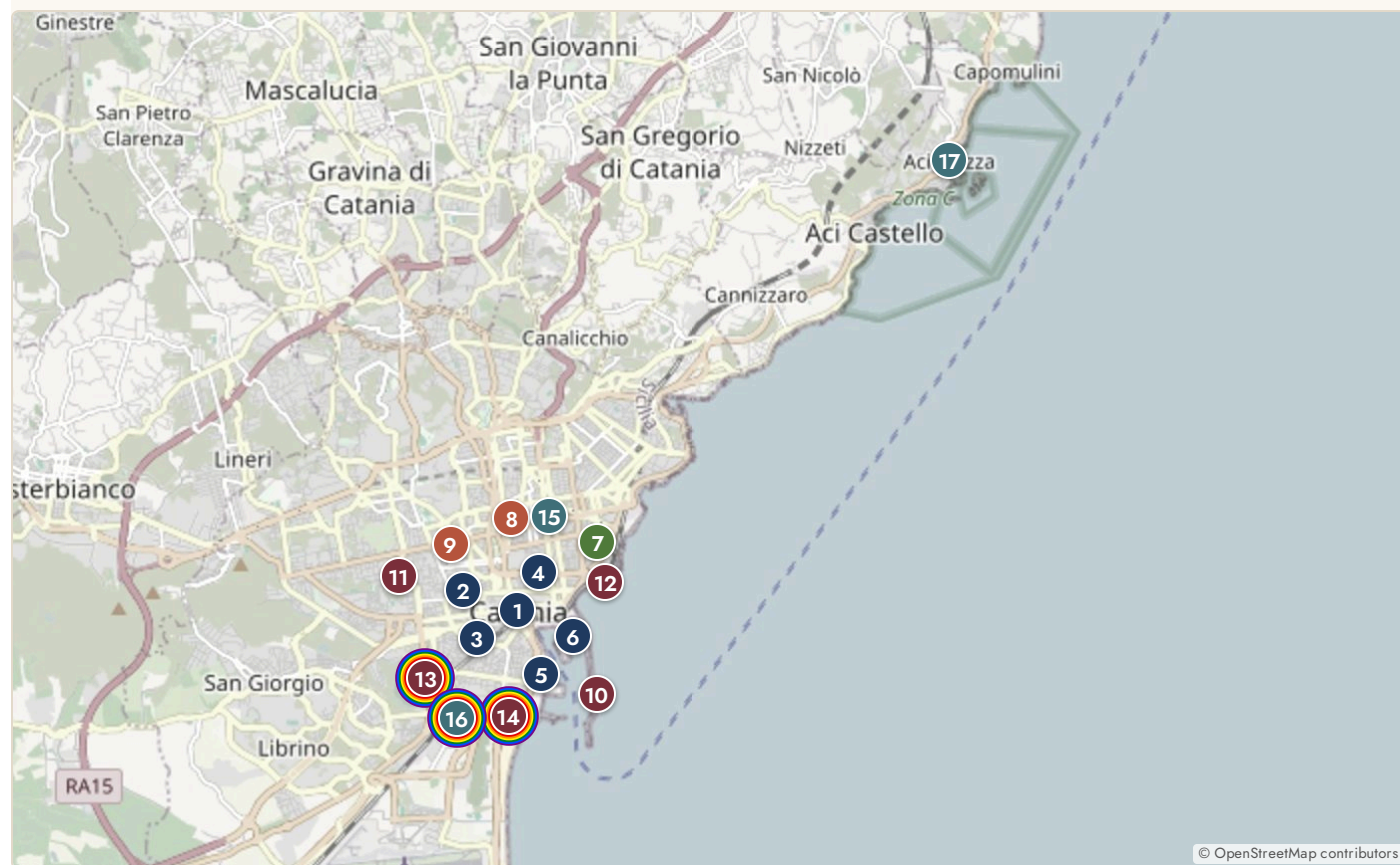
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WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 10 **Giardino Ibleo** — A 19th-century garden at Ibla's tip with a balustrade over the valley — the evening passeggiata. Free.
- 11 **Santa Maria delle Scale** — Walk down 300-plus steps from the upper town for the postcard view of Ibla; take the bus back up.
- 12 **Chiafura** — A hillside of cave homes lived in until the 1950s; climb to San Matteo for the whole panorama.
- 13 **Punta Secca** — Montalbano's seafront house beside a little lighthouse — a real B&B, seen from the beach.

II Catania

A black-and-gold Baroque city rebuilt from lava stone after 1693, with Etna at the end of almost every street. Loud, scruffy, far less touristy than Taormina, and one of Italy's great eating cities: the fish market in the morning, granita mid-morning, grilled meat at night. Queer life is easy here, on the Alessi steps.



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 ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Piazza del Duomo & the elephant** — The lava-stone elephant carrying an obelisk, Vaccarini's cathedral of Sant'Agata and the Porta Uzeda gate down to the market. Best at dusk.
- 2 **Via dei Crociferi & the Badia dome** — Four churches in 200 m under the arch of San Benedetto; climb the Badia di Sant'Agata's dome for Etna and the Duomo.
- 3 **Monastero dei Benedettini** — One of Europe's largest monasteries, now the university: lava-buried Roman houses, twin cloisters, a Giancarlo De Carlo library. Tours daily 10:00–17:00, €10 (65+ €7.50).
- 4 **Teatro Romano** — A Roman theatre half-buried among houses. €8, daily 9:00–19:00, every day of the year.
- 5 **Castello Ursino** — Frederick II's castle once stood on the sea — the 1669 lava pushed the shore away. Civic art inside, daily 9:00–19:00.
- 6 **Teatro Massimo Bellini** — An 1890 opera house for Catania's composer — check the autumn season for a night out.



Julian Lupyan · CCO

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 7 **La Pescheria** — Swordfish heads, sea urchins and dialect shouting behind Porta Uzeda — Mon–Sat mornings only. Go before 10:00, in shoes you don't mind wetting.

CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 8 **Pasticceria Savia** — The benchmark cone-shaped arancino, *iris* (fried ricotta brioche) and *cipollina* — eaten standing at the counter.
- 9 **Seltz at the kiosks** — Order a *seltz limone e sale* — soda, fresh lemon and a pinch of salt — at the historic street kiosks.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 10 **Osteria Antica Marina** — A classic seafood osteria practically inside the market; choose from the raw-fish display and book dinner.
- 11 **Via Plebiscito grills** — After 20:00, charcoal braziers grill horse steaks and patties on the street — gritty and working-class. Skip it if horse is a no.
- 12 **Me Cumpari Turiddu** — Sicilian classics with a light touch in a retro grocery, and 200 Sicilian wines — a good first dinner.
- 13 **Nievski** LGBTQ+ — A historic pub-trattoria on the Alessi steps with a mixed, queer-friendly crowd; on warm evenings everyone sits on the steps.

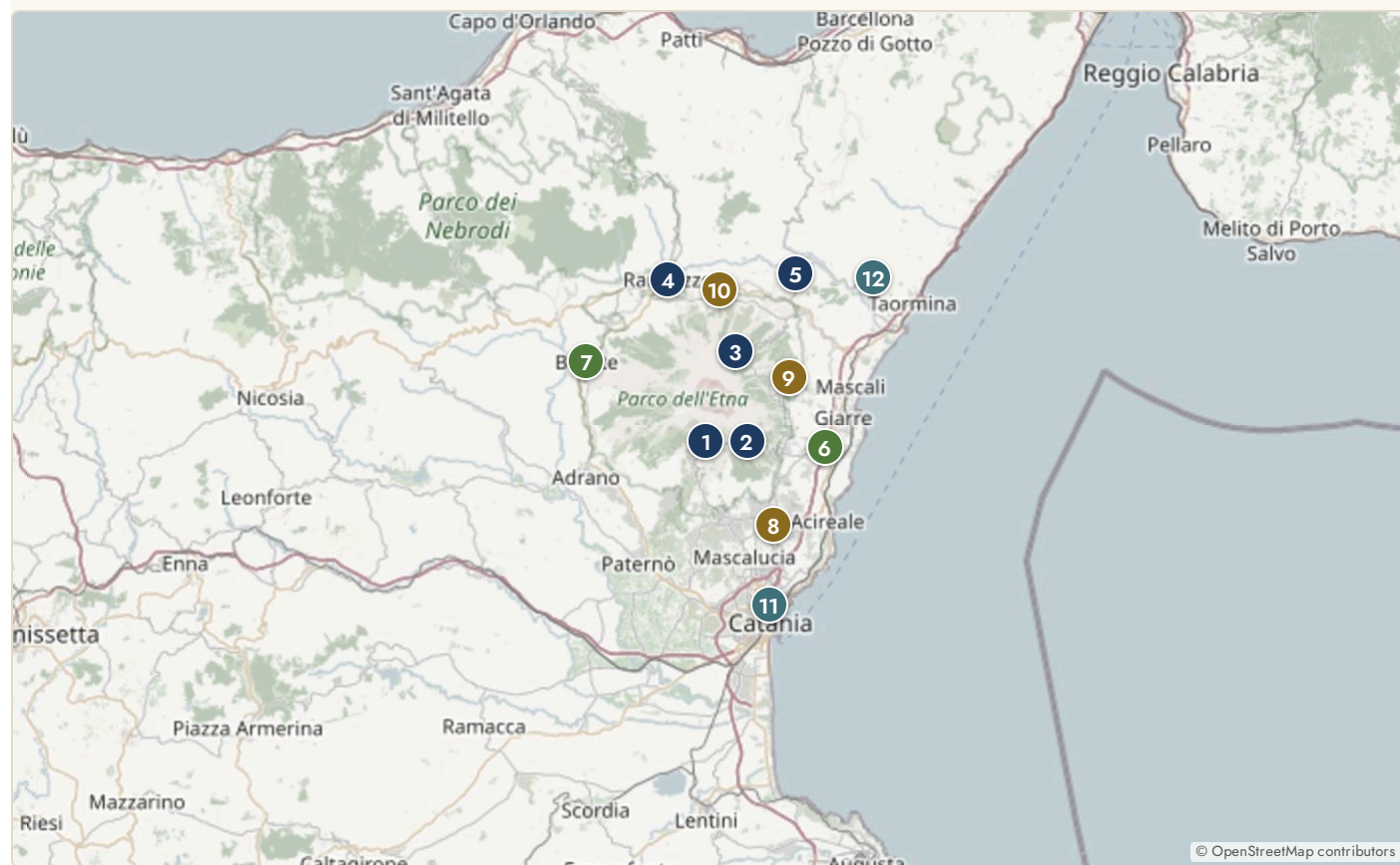
- 14 **Hasta Siempre & Buio** LGBTQ+ — Hasta Siempre on the Alessi steps is listed as Catania's gay and alternative bar; Buio calls itself an LGBT wine and cocktail bar, with live music. Nightlife starts late.

WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 15 **Via Etna & Villa Bellini** — The 3 km main street aimed at the volcano, the evening passeggiata, and a 19th-century garden whose upper terraces frame Etna.
- 16 **Le Capannine, La Playa** LGBTQ+ — The best-known gay beach near Catania, on the long sandy Playa south of the port — summer events, no nudism.
- 17 **Aci Castello & Aci Trezza** — The lava coast north: a Norman castle on black basalt, then the Cyclops' sea stacks and Verga's fishing village — sunset fish at Il Covo Marino.

I2 Etna & Its Villages

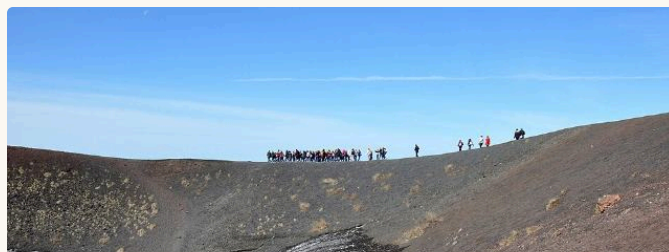
Europe's most active volcano is a country of its own: lunar craters, then chestnut and pine forest, then terraced vineyards of black sand ringed by lava-stone villages. Autumn is harvest, festival Sundays and roasted chestnuts. Summit access changes with the volcano's mood — plan flexibly.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Rifugio Sapienza & the Silvestri craters** — The south-side hub at 1,900 m; the extinct 1892 craters beside the car park are free to walk. One AST bus a day from Catania. It can be 15°C colder than the coast.
- 2 **Funivia dell'Etna** — The cable car to 2,500 m, with 4x4 buses and a guide towards 2,900 m on the full package (sunset tour €82). Wind and eruptions often stop it — buy on the day.
- 3 **Piano Provenzana** — The quieter north-side base among pines, with jeep tours toward the summit — pairs with the north-slope wineries.

- 4 **Randazzo** — A medieval town built entirely of dark lava stone, closest to the summit yet never destroyed — the heart of northern Etna wine.
- 5 **Castiglione di Sicilia** — A hill town on a rock above the Alcantara valley, with a Byzantine “cuba” chapel in the vines — the lunch stop on the wine road.



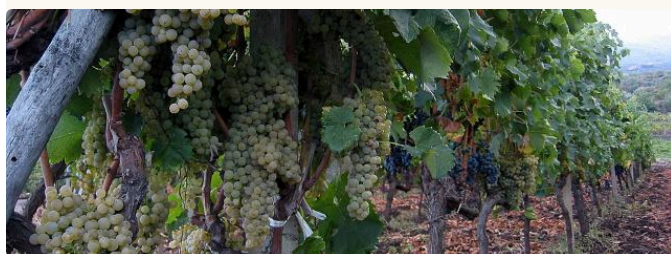
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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 6 **Zafferana Etnea & the Ottobrata** — Etna's honey town; the 2026 Ottobrata fills the Sundays of October (4, 11, 18, 25) with honey, mushrooms, chestnuts and wine. Arrive by 10:00.
- 7 **Bronte pistachios** — Bright-green DOP pistachios grown on raw lava; the festival's second weekend is 2–4 October 2026.

SHOPPING & WINE

- 8 **Benanti** — The family house (1734) that put Etna wine on the map, 20 minutes from Catania; tastings with a light lunch, by booking.
- 9 **Barone di Villagrande** — Since 1727 on the east slope, known for Etna Bianco Superiore; sea-view terraces.
- 10 **The north-slope wine road** — Tenuta delle Terre Nere, Planeta's Feudo di Mezzo, Pietradolce and Passopisciaro along the SS120 — all by appointment; book a week ahead in harvest.



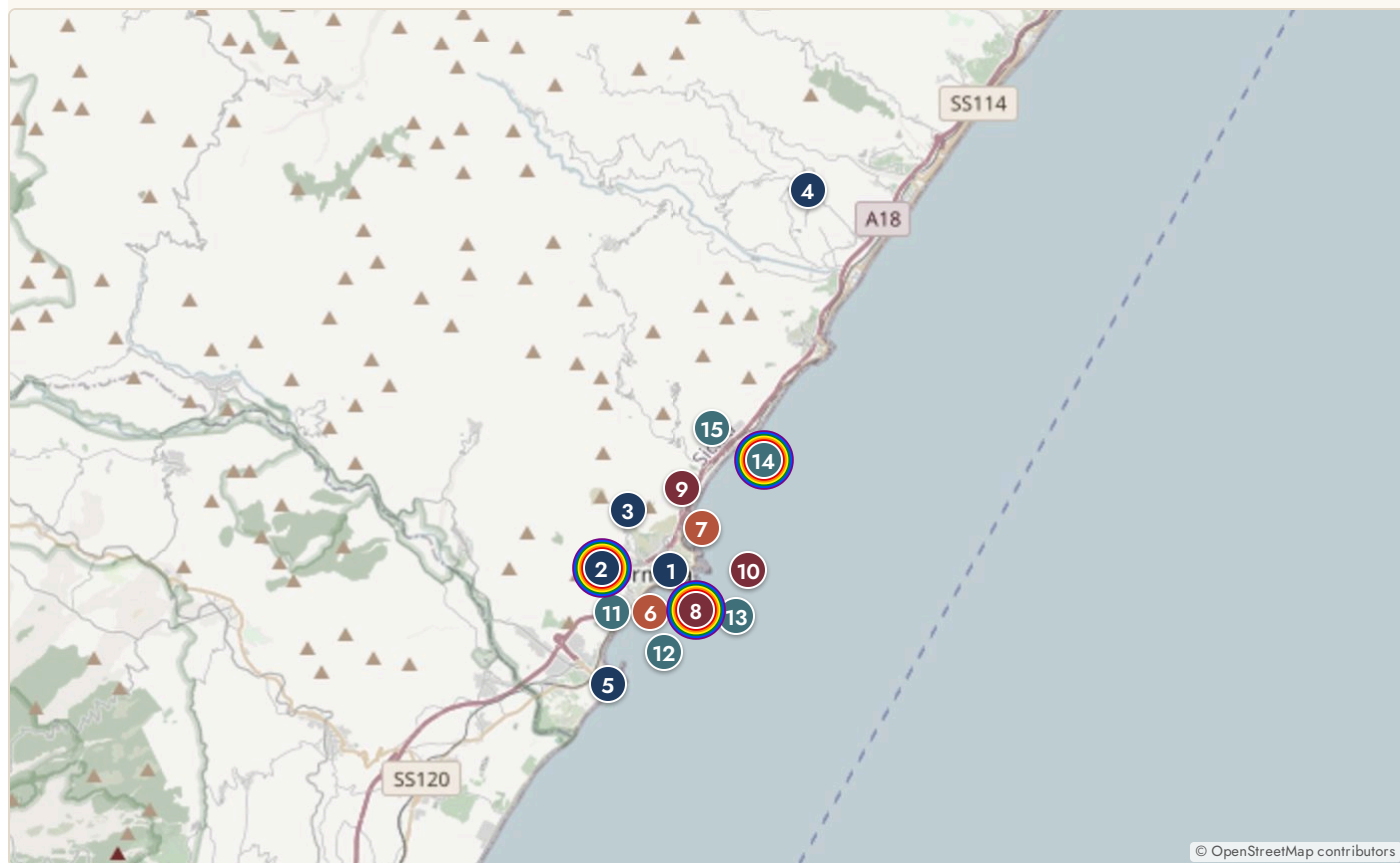
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WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- **Summit rules** — Unguided walking is allowed up to about 2,900 m; above that only with authorised volcanological guides, and only when the alert level allows. Check the current ordinance the day before.
- 11 **The Circumetnea railway** — A narrow-gauge line around the volcano through lava fields and pistachio groves; buses replace trains Catania–Paternò, and trains run on to Randazzo on weekdays.
- 12 **Alcantara gorge** — A basalt-column canyon with icy water: the €2 municipal stairs (to early November) or the private park with a lift (about €10–13).

I3 Taormina & the Ionian Coast

Taormina hangs on a cliff between Etna and the sea. It has drawn artists, writers and gay travellers since the 1890s, and in October it gets back some of its calm. Stay for the late light over the Greek theatre, then drop down to the coves, fishing villages and Godfather hill towns.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Teatro Antico** — A Greek-Roman theatre framed by Etna and the bay — one of the great views of the Mediterranean. €14; daily 9:00–19:45. Opening time or the last hour, away from cruise groups.
- 2 **Casa Cuseni & the von Gloeden story**  — The gay English painter Robert Kitson's house; Wilhelm von Gloeden's photographs of local youths drew Wilde, Gide and later Capote and Williams to Taormina.
- 3 **Castelmola** — A village 5 km above Taormina with views down onto the theatre, and Bar Turrisi's cheeky décor and almond wine.

- 4 **Savoca & Forza d'Agrò** — The Godfather hill towns: Bar Vitelli, where Michael asks for Apollonia's hand, the wedding church and a Capuchin crypt.
- 5 **Giardini Naxos** — Sicily's first Greek colony (734 BC) on the Schisò cape, and a long seafront below Taormina.



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CAFÉS, PASTRY & GELATO

- 6 **Wunderbar** — The belvedere café of Tennessee Williams, Capote and the Burtons — pricey, but one aperitivo for the view.
- 7 **Bam Bar** — The town's favourite granita — mulberry, almond, fig — with warm brioche. Queue in the morning.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 8 **Morgana**  — A chic garden cocktail bar off Corso Umberto, long popular with gay travellers.
- 9 **La Capinera** — Pietro D'Agostino's one-star creative Sicilian cooking on a terrace over the Ionian.
- 10 **Otto Geleng** — Eight tables at the Grand Hotel Timeo facing Etna; one star. Often seasonal — check October.



Scott Wylie · CC BY 4.0

WALKS, BEACHES & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 11 **Corso Umberto & Piazza IX Aprile** — Gate to gate along the main street, with the checkerboard terrace halfway; take the side stairs for quiet corners.
- 12 **Villa Comunale** — Florence Trevelyan's Victorian garden of brick follies and sea views — the best bench in town. Free.
- 13 **Isola Bella** — A tiny reserve island on a pebble spit, about €6. The cable car to Mazzarò reopened in March 2026.
- 14 **Rocce Bianche**  — Rocky white coves at Spisone, reached by steep paths — long frequented by gay swimmers.
- 15 **Letojanni** — A real fishing village one train stop north: pebble beach, seafront walk, cheaper seafood.

Palermo, from the Palatine Chapel to the sea

Nine hundred years of Palermo in half a day — go early for the chapel, eat in the market, and finish on the sea lawns at sunset.

1 Start: Palazzo dei Normanni

The Cappella Palatina at opening, before the groups.

2 The Cathedral

Along Corso Vittorio Emanuele; add the roofs.

3 Quattro Canti

The Baroque crossroads of Via Maqueda and the Corso.

4 Piazza Pretoria & Piazza Bellini

The Fountain of Shame, then the Martorana, San Cataldo and a cannolo at Santa Caterina.

5 Ballarò

A detour south for panelle and arancine among the stalls.

6 The Kalsa

Via Alloro to Palazzo Abatellis and the ruins of Santa Maria dello Spasimo.

7 Finish: the Foro Italico

The sea lawns at sunset — or north up Via Maqueda to the Teatro Massimo and a drink at Exit.



Fontana Pretoria — This Photo was taken by Wolfgang Moroder. Feel f · CC BY-SA 3.0



The Martorana — Livioandronico2013 · CC BY-SA 4.0

A loop around Ortigia

Twenty-seven centuries on a 1 km island — best started at the morning market and finished with a spritz on the sea walls.

1 Start: the Temple of Apollo

Just over the Ponte Umberto.

2 The market

Via De Benedictis — fish, capers, almonds (closed Sundays).

3 Piazza Duomo

The cathedral built round the Temple of Athena.

4 Fonte Aretusa

The papyrus spring on the harbour.

5 Castello Maniace

Frederick II's fortress at the tip, along the Lungomare.

6 The Giudecca

The old Jewish quarter and the underground Miqwè.

7 Finish: Forte Vigliena

The swimming platform, then a spritz on the sea walls.



Castello Maniace — Misterchry82 · CC BY-SA 4.0

What to eat & drink

Sicilian food is Greek, Arab, Norman and Spanish on one plate — and autumn is a good season: chestnuts, porcini, new olive oil and the Etna harvest.

DISH	WHAT IT IS	WHERE & WHEN
Arancine / arancini	Fried rice balls — round and feminine in Palermo, conical and masculine in Catania	Everywhere; 13 Dec is arancine day in Palermo
Panelle & crocchè	Chickpea fritters and potato croquettes in a bun	Palermo street stalls
Sfincione	Thick, spongy pizza with onion, tomato, anchovy, caciocavallo	Palermo, from three-wheeled vans
Pane ca' meusa	Veal spleen bun, “schietta” or “maritata” with cheese	Porta Carbone, Antica Focacceria
Pasta con le sarde	Sardines, wild fennel, raisins, pine nuts, toasted crumbs	Palermo, spring–summer
Pasta alla Norma	Fried aubergine, tomato, salted ricotta	Catania, all year
Busiate al pesto trapanese	Twisted pasta, almond-tomato-basil pesto	Trapani and Erice
Cous cous di pesce	Couscous soaked in fish broth — the Arab legacy	Trapani, San Vito Lo Capo
Caponata & sarde a beccafico	Sweet-sour aubergine; stuffed rolled sardines	Everywhere
Cannoli & cassata	Ricotta in fried shells; ricotta, sponge and marzipan	Pastry shops; convent sweets
Granita & brioche	Almond, pistachio, coffee, mulberry — for breakfast	The east coast, all year
Modica chocolate & Bronte pistachio	Grainy cold-worked chocolate; DOP “green gold”	Bonajuto; Bronte festival in October
Wines	Nero d'Avola, Etna Rosso, Marsala, Malvasia, Passito di Pantelleria	Noto, Etna, Marsala, Salina, Pantelleria



The day's catch — Lucarelli · CC BY-SA 3.0



Cannoli — mat's eye · CC BY 2.0

Festivals by month

Sicily's calendar is saints, harvests and processions — and a busy Pride season in early summer.

MONTH	WHAT'S ON
October	Zafferana Ottobrata (Sundays 4–25 Oct 2026); Bronte pistachio festival (2–4 Oct)
November	Festa dei Morti (1–2 Nov): martorana fruit and ossa di morto biscuits everywhere
December	Santa Lucia in Syracuse (13 Dec, octave 20 Dec); nativity scenes; the Customaci living crib
February	Sant'Agata in Catania (3–5 Feb), one of the world's biggest religious festivals; Carnival in Acireale; almond blossom in Agrigento
March–April	Holy Week — Trapani's 24-hour Misteri procession (Good Friday 26 Mar 2027); Easter 28 Mar
May	Infiorata di Noto (mid-May); INDA Greek drama in Syracuse's theatre (May–July); Sicilia Queer Filmfest (Palermo, late May)
June	Palermo, Catania and Aeolian Prides; Taormina Film Fest
July	Festino di Santa Rosalia, Palermo (10–15 Jul); Syracuse Pride; Caltagirone's lit staircase (24–25 Jul)
August	Ferragosto (15 Aug); Palio dei Normanni, Piazza Armerina; Agrigento Pride (2026: 29 Aug)
September	Cous Cous Fest, San Vito Lo Capo; Bronte pistachio festival begins



Sant'Agata, Catania — Effems · CC BY-SA 4.0

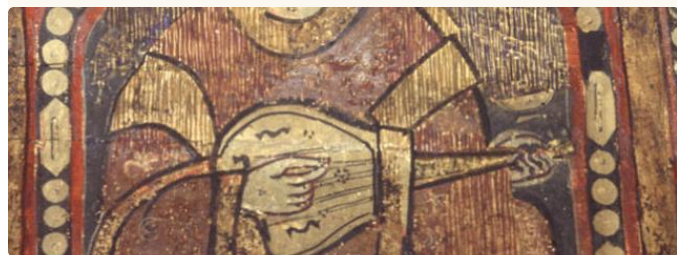


Infiorata di Noto — Effems · CC BY-SA 4.0

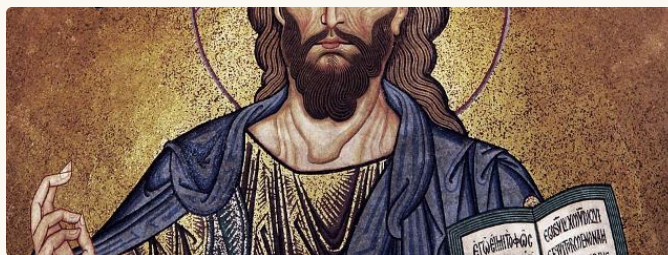
Three thousand years of history

Sicani, Elymians and Phoenicians; Greeks from 734 BC, when Syracuse rivalled Athens; Rome's granary; Byzantium; the Arabs (827–1091), who brought citrus, sugar and couscous; the Normans and Frederick II, “Stupor Mundi”; the Sicilian Vespers (1282) and five centuries of Spain; the 1693 earthquake and the Baroque rebuilding; Garibaldi's landing at Marsala (1860); emigration to the Americas, including Montreal; the Allied landing (1943); autonomy (1946); and the antimafia years after Falcone and Borsellino (1992).

ARAB-NORMAN UNESCO SITE	WHERE	DON'T MISS
Palazzo dei Normanni & Cappella Palatina	Palermo	Byzantine mosaics under an Islamic muqarnas ceiling
San Giovanni degli Eremiti	Palermo	Red domes and a cloister garden
Martorana & San Cataldo	Palermo	12th-century mosaics; three red domes
Cathedral	Palermo	Royal tombs, including Frederick II
La Zisa	Palermo	An Arab-style summer palace
Cefalù Cathedral	Cefalù	The Christ Pantocrator
Monreale Cathedral & cloister	Monreale	6,400 m ² of gold mosaics



Cappella Palatina — Unknown 12th century painter, unknown photograph · Public domain



Christ Pantocrator, Cefalù — Andreas Wahra · CC BY-SA 3.0

Two bases for a month

Palermo, about 15 days

The Arab-Norman monuments, the markets and street food, the opera and the gay bar, with trains and buses to Monreale, Cefalù, Segesta, Erice and Agrigento. Stay in the Kalsa, around Via Maqueda or near the Politeama. Against it: traffic, noise, some scruffiness.

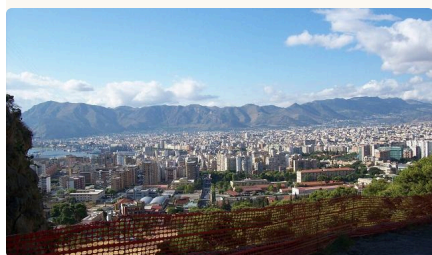
Ortigia (Syracuse), about 15 days

A walkable island old town with the sea on three sides and swimming platforms into October; easy days to Noto, Modica, Ragusa, Catania, Etna, Taormina and Malta. Against it: small, touristy in summer, and a ZTL for the car.

Or instead

Cefalù (beach and town, an hour from Palermo by train), Catania (lively, cheaper, the Etna hub), Taormina (beautiful and historically gay-friendly, but pricey and largely shut November–March), Noto (a Baroque jewel for a car-based stay).

A 30-day rhythm: days 1–3 settling into Palermo; days 4–10 two or three day trips a week (Monreale, Cefalù, Segesta and Erice, Mondello) with rest days between; days 11–13 a loop through Trapani, Marsala and Agrigento to the Villa del Casale; day 14 across to Ortigia; days 15–21 Syracuse and the Baroque towns; days 22–27 Etna, Catania, Taormina and perhaps Malta; days 28–30 slow days, flying out of Catania. Keep one “nothing day” a week.



Palermo from Monte Pellegrino — Tripoli99 · CC BY-SA 3.0



Ortigia from the sea — Benjamin Smith · CC BY-SA 4.0



Cefalù — Berthold Werner · CC BY-SA 4.0

The islands — the Aeolians, the Egadi and Pantelleria — and a crossing to Malta have their own chapters, starting on the next page.

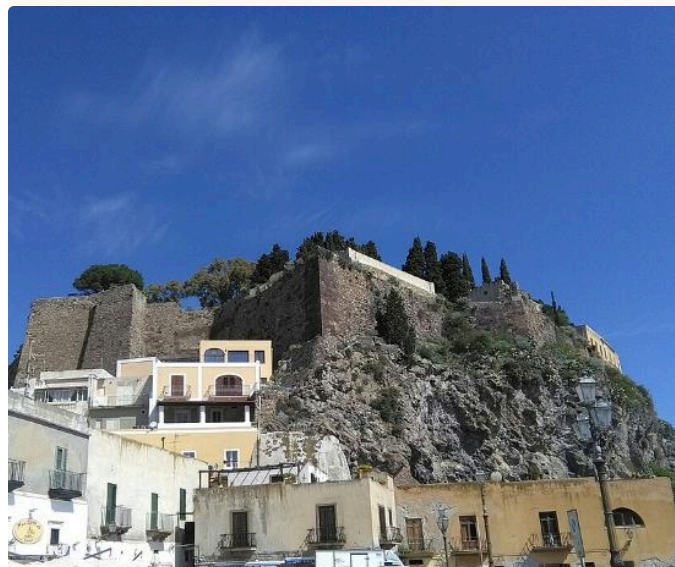
Islands & extensions

Seven volcanic islands to the north, three flat and craggy ones off Trapani, a lava island near Tunisia — and Malta, 1 h 45 from Pozzallo. Build in a spare day: ferries cancel in rough seas.



DESTINATION	GETTING THERE	BEST AS
Lipari & Salina	Hydrofoil from Milazzo, 1–2 h	3–4 nights
Stromboli & Vulcano	Hydrofoil from Milazzo or Lipari	1–2 nights (Stromboli), day (Vulcano)
The Egadi: Favignana & Levanzo	Hydrofoil from Trapani, 20–30 min	Day or 1–2 nights
Pantelleria	Flight from Trapani or Palermo (35–50 min), or overnight ferry	3 nights
Malta	Virtu catamaran Pozzallo–Valletta, 1 h 45	2–3 nights

Lipari & Salina



jeanne boley - CC BY-SA 4.0



chrisaliv - CC BY-SA 3.0

GETTING THERE Liberty Lines hydrofoils from Milazzo reach Vulcano in 45 minutes and Lipari in about an hour (roughly €20–30); Siremar car ferries are slower and cheaper. Leave the car in Milazzo. From October the winter timetable thins out and many Salina hotels close by late October.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Seven volcanic islands, a UNESCO site, traded obsidian across the Mediterranean in the Neolithic and were Greek, Roman, Arab and Norman in turn. Lipari's castle rock holds a sequence of settlement going back 6,000 years; Salina grows capers and the sweet Malvasia wine.

THINGS TO DO

Lipari's castle & museum

The Bernabò Brea museum has the world's largest collection of Greek theatre masks — allow half a day.

Salina

Pollara's half-crater where *Il Postino* was filmed, capers drying at Malfa, a Malvasia tasting at Hauner or Capofaro.

Quattrocchi

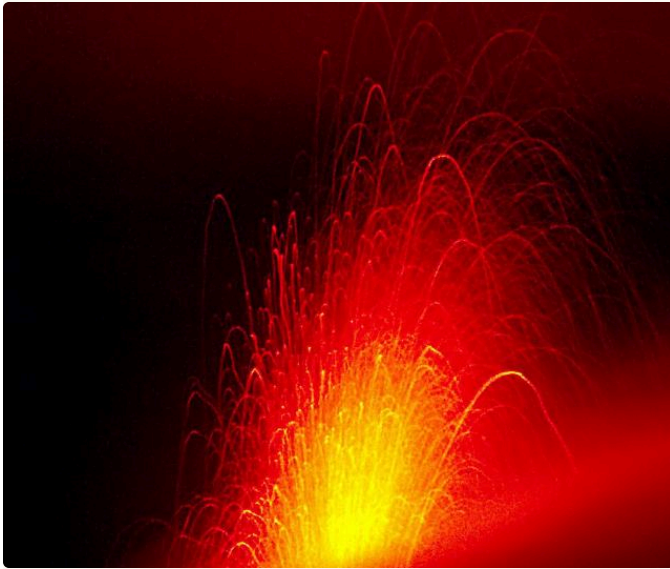
The classic view south to Vulcano and its sea stacks.

Pane cunzato at Lingua

Granita and loaded bread at Da Alfredo by the lagoon.

Tips: Base on Lipari for practicality, Salina for romance. The islands held their own Pride in June 2026.

Stromboli & Vulcano



Heinrich Stürzl · CC BY-SA 4.0



Carsten Steger · CC BY-SA 4.0

GETTING THERE Hydrofoils from Milazzo or Lipari; Stromboli's service thins sharply in winter. On Stromboli you may walk unguided only to 290 m, or to 400 m with an authorised guide (helmet and mask); the summit is closed. Vulcano's crater walk opens on a gas-and-wind traffic light.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Stromboli has erupted almost continuously for thousands of years — the “lighthouse of the Mediterranean”. Vulcano gave its name to every volcano on earth; the Romans thought it was Vulcan's forge.

THINGS TO DO

The 400 m viewpoint

A guided sunset walk to watch the explosions.

L'Osservatorio

Pizza on a terrace facing the summit's night fireworks.

Sciara del Fuoco by boat

An evening boat idles below the lava slope — the easy way to see it.

Vulcano's crater & mud pool

An hour's climb to the rim, then the hot mud pool, reopened in April 2026 — take off silver jewellery.

Tips: Build in a spare day for cancelled hydrofoils. Check the latest ordinance before booking a guide.

Favignana & Levanzo



giomodica · CC BY 3.0

GETTING THERE Liberty Lines from Trapani: Favignana in 20–30 minutes, Levanzo in 25, Marettimo in 1–1.5 hours. Winter timetables apply from autumn; book Levanzo returns early.

A LITTLE HISTORY

The Florio family's tuna empire made Favignana rich; its 1880s cannery, now a museum, tells the story of the *mattanza*. Levanzo's cave holds Paleolithic deer and Neolithic painted tuna.

THINGS TO DO

Favignana by bicycle

Flat enough to loop in a day: tuff quarries, Bue Marino, Cala Rossa.

Grotta del Genovese

Levanzo's cave art — €42 guided with transport, mornings only, book 48 h ahead.

The Florio tonnara

The cannery museum, usually April–October.

Marettimo

A car-free mountain island with a 4–5 hour trail to Punta Troia castle.

Tips: Favignana and Marettimo shut down a lot from November. Wear sturdy shoes for Cala Rossa's steps.

3 NIGHTS · FLIGHT 35–50 MIN

Pantelleria



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GETTING THERE Subsidised DAT flights from Trapani and Palermo (confirmed to 31 Oct 2026, reportedly to March 2027), or a 6–7 hour ferry from Trapani, often overnight. Rent a car on the island.

A LITTLE HISTORY

A black volcanic island closer to Tunisia than to Sicily, with Arab-era dry-stone domed houses (*dammusi*), walled gardens for single orange trees, and bush vines trained low against the wind — a UNESCO-listed practice.

THINGS TO DO

Specchio di Venere

A jade crater lake fed by warm springs, with clay on the shore.

The ring road

40 km past the Elephant Arch and the hot-spring pools of Gadir.

Passito tastings

Donnafugata's Ben Ryé at Khamma, and De Bartoli's Bukkuram.

Montagna Grande

National-park trails to 836 m and the steam cave.

Tips: Stay in a restored dammuso. Swimming is from rocks only. Verify winter flights.

Malta



Trajinema · CC BY 4.0

GETTING THERE Virtu Ferries' catamaran from Pozzallo (south of Modica) to Valletta's Grand Harbour, about 1 h 45, usually daily. Bring your passport — the ferry checks ID even inside Schengen.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Malta was Sicilian for much of its history — Norman, Aragonese, then the Knights of St John from 1530, before Napoleon and the British. You'll hear Sicilian in the Maltese language.

THINGS TO DO

Valletta

St John's Co-Cathedral and Caravaggio's *Beheading of St John*.

Mdina

The silent walled city at dusk.

The Three Cities

The ferry across the Grand Harbour and a hand-rowed boat back.

An LGBTQ+ evening

Café Society on Valletta's St John Street — all in your Malta guide.

Tips: Your Malta & Gozo guide in the Travel folder has everything; Malta ranks near the top of Europe for LGBTQ+ rights.

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